Examining Racial Identity Responses Among People with Middle Eastern and North African Ancestry in the American Community Survey

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Abstract

People with Middle Eastern and North African (MENA) backgrounds living in the United States are defined and classified as White by current Federal standards for race and ethnicity, yet many MENA people do not identify as White in surveys, such as those conducted by the U.S. Census Bureau. Instead, they often select "Some Other Race", if it is provided, and write in MENA responses such as Arab, Iranian, or Middle Eastern. In processing survey data for public release, the Census Bureau classifies these responses as White in accordance with Federal guidance set by the U.S. Office of Management and Budget. Research that uses these edited public data relies on limited information on MENA people's racial identification. To address this limitation, we obtained unedited race responses in the nationally representative American Community Survey from 2005-2019 to better understand how people of MENA ancestry report their race. We also use these data to compare the demographic, cultural, socioeconomic, and contextual characteristics of MENA individuals who identify as White versus those who do not identify as White. We find that one in four MENA people do not select White alone as their racial identity, despite official guidance that defines "White" as people having origins in any of the original peoples of Europe, the Middle East, or North Africa. A variety of individual and contextual factors are associated with this choice, and some of these factors operate differently for U.S.-born and foreign-born MENA people living in the United States.

Keyword*:* Race, Identity, Middle Eastern and North African, Census Bureau

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Results from the 2020 Census show that over 3.5 million people in the United States reported a Middle Eastern and North African (MENA) identity in response to the question on race. This includes people who reported a MENA response alone or in combination with another group, though the majority (over 2.5 million people) identified as MENA alone (Marks et al., 2023). These results show the size of the MENA population, approximately 1% of the U.S. total population, is almost twice the size of the Native Hawaiian and Other Pacific Islander alone or in combination population, which makes up approximately 0.5% of the U.S. population (Jones et al., 2021). Yet, relative to this group and others, there is a dearth of data on the MENA population in the U.S., which makes it difficult to measure and subsequently address issues of social and economic inequality among people of MENA ancestry. The lack of information on the MENA population is primarily due to Federal standards set by the Office of Management and Budget (OMB) in 1997 that mandate a minimum set of race and ethnicity categories which do not include a distinct MENA category. Thus, many Federal surveys used to produce population statistics by race and ethnicity, as well as more expansive Federal statistics on socioeconomic status, educational achievement, health, and more, do not provide information to understand the conditions and characteristics of the MENA population.

The collection, categorization, and tabulation of Federal race and ethnicity data, including statistics produced by the Census Bureau, are determined by Federal standards set by OMB's 1997 directive (Directive 15). These standards established five minimum racial categories (White, Black or African American, American Indian or Alaska Native, Asian, Native Hawaiian or Other Pacific Islander), and two ethnicity categories (Hispanic or Latino; Non-Hispanic or Latino) that continue to be in in effect today. MENA peoples are classified under the White category, which is defined as "people having origins in any of the original peoples of Europe, the

Middle East, or North Africa" (OMB, 1997). The standards do not include MENA as a distinct minimum response category, meaning that while Federal agencies, such as the Census Bureau, may opt to collect data on detailed groups (e.g., MENA groups such as Lebanese, Arab, Iranian, etc.) on a case-by-case basis, it is not mandated by the standards. Moreover, any detailed group information must be able to be aggregated within one of the minimum categories, such as White. It is worth noting that despite the latitude provided by the standards for collecting more detailed group information, the 2020 Census was the first time since the first census in 1790 that a Census Bureau survey offered a write-in space under the White minimum category for respondents to provide such detailed group information. It is also worth mentioning that while many other North American and European nations do not collect population-level data on race and ethnicity, of those that do, including Canada, England, and Ireland, the U.S. is the only one to aggregate MENA responses as White (Maghbouleh et al., 2022). The Census Bureau is also required by the U.S. Congress to use the category "Some Other Race" for the decennial census and the American Community Survey, a large, annual demographic survey (Science, State, Justice, Commerce, and Related Agencies Appropriations Act, 2006). This residual category includes all other responses not covered by the five minimum race categories defined in the OMB standards.

While MENA peoples are classified by race as White in the U.S., a growing body of cross-disciplinary literature indicates not all people of MENA ancestry self-identify as racially White (e.g., Maghbouleh et al., 2022). Furthermore, if a person writes in a MENA response on a survey (e.g., under the Some Other Race write-in space), Federal agencies must aggregate MENA responses as White during the normal editing process before releasing data publicly, even if the original response did not have the White checkbox selected (OMB, 1997). As a result, the proportions of the White population who identify as MENA and those who identify as

European, as well as the proportions of the MENA population who identify as White and those who do not, cannot be determined using the minimum race category tabulations commonly published and available in public data products. Similarly, any meaningful social, demographic, or economic differences between MENA and non-MENA White (European) individuals, as well as within MENA communities themselves, cannot be ascertained from the tabulated minimum race category data, which is edited in accordance with Directive 15. While Federal agencies can use their discretion to disaggregate responses classified within the White category on an ad hoc basis (e.g., MENA detailed groups vs. European detailed groups), very few have, which cumulatively has given rise to a notable dearth of data on the MENA community.

In this study, we attempt to fill this knowledge gap by using original *unedited* information on the race reporting of MENA respondents (identified via ancestry) to the American Community Survey (ACS) from 2005-2019. These are restricted-use data from the U.S. Census Bureau that reflect the original responses expressed by the survey respondent, prior to classification to meet the minimum race categories set by OMB. With these data, we identify the proportion of MENA respondents who choose a White racial identity compared to other options, including Some Other Race. We then explore the demographic, socioeconomic, and contextual factors associated with different racial responses among people of MENA ancestry, including differences in racial response patterns for U.S.-born versus foreign-born people of MENA ancestry. By using a large, longstanding, and nationally representative survey, we extend prior research that has previously relied on small, localized, or qualitative samples with rich data on racial identification to explore these questions (e.g., Ajrouch and Jamal 2007; Cainkar 2008; Compton et al. 2012; Shryock 2008, c.f. Maghbouleh et al., 2022). We find that approximately one in four MENA people do not select “White” alone as their racial identity despite the official

definition from Directive 15. A variety of individual and contextual factors are associated with this choice, and some of these factors operate differently for native-born and foreign-born MENA people living in the United States. These findings underscore the need for better data on this diverse population.

The MENA Population of the United States

The MENA population, also referred to by the decolonial term, "Southwest Asian and North African" (SWANA), includes people of Arab descent (e.g., Lebanese, Syrian), people of non-Arab descent (e.g., Iranian, Turkish), and people of North African descent (e.g., Algerian, Moroccan). This classification is geographically inclusive of countries in the Middle East and North Africa region of the world, as well as transnational ethnic communities within the region (e.g., Assyrian, Kurdish, Berber).[1]

Peoples of MENA descent are diverse in terms of religion, ethnicity, culture, nationality, language, employment, socioeconomic status, and the political context under which they or their ancestors immigrated to the United States (Asi and Beaulieu 2013**;** Awad et al. 2019; Cumoletti and Batalova 2018; Kayyali 2013; Terrazas 2011; Zong and Batalova 2015). About half of the MENA population in the United States was born in the United States, with about 70% reporting Middle Eastern ancestries and 30% reporting North African ancestries (Read 2008; Terrazas 2011; Zong and Batalova 2015). The number of people of MENA descent in the United States has increased over the past few decades with the Arab population alone, a subset of the broader MENA community, growing by approximately 75% between 1990 and 2010 (Asi and Beaulieu

[1] As will be discussed, the precise geographic boundaries of the MENA region vary based on source (e.g., U.S. Census Bureau, United Nations Statistics Division). For the purposes of this analysis, the following are included in our classification of the MENA population for these analyses (discussed in more detail in Methods): Armenian, Algerian, Alhucemas, Arab or Arabic, Assyrian/Chaldean/Syriac, Bahraini, Bedouin, Berber, Egyptian, Emirati, Iranian, Iraqi, Israeli, Jordanian, Kurdish, Kuria Muria Islander, Kuwaiti, Lebanese, Libyan, Mauritanian, Middle Eastern, Moroccan, Muscat, North African, Omani, Palestinian, Qatari, Rio De Oro, Saudi Arabian, Syrian, Trucial States, Tunisian, Turkish, and/or Yemeni ancestry.

2013) and the total number of U.S. immigrants from the MENA region doubling between 2000 and 2019 (Harjanto and Batalova 2022).

Historical Background on MENA and Whiteness in the U.S. Context

The current classification of MENA individuals in the U.S. as White is tied to a dynamic history of immigration and naturalization laws. Historically, many of these laws enforced quotas on immigrants arriving from certain countries of origin as well as their rights to citizenship upon arrival in the U.S. (Gualtieri 2001; Naber 2000; Samhan 1999). The first wave of MENA immigration to the U.S., starting in the late 1800s, was largely comprised of Christians from current-day Lebanon, Palestine, Israel, and Syria pursuing economic opportunities (Zarrugh 2016). As discussed in Cainkar (2016), this first wave of MENA immigrants quickly bridged cultural differences and resembled other low-status "White" European ethnic groups at the time who also faced discrimination and prejudice (see also Abdulrahim 2008; Gordon 1964; Kulczycki and Lobo 2002, 2014; Terrazas 2011), which scholars associate in large part to their Christian religious affiliation and physical appearance (Cainkar 2002; Read 2008). Still, there was one notable difference between these MENA immigrants and similarly low-status, White ethnic immigrant groups. With their national origin from the Asian continent, MENA immigrants could not claim legal citizenship in U.S. courts – a privilege extended only to White immigrants of European descent until 1952 (Aziz, forthcoming; Cainker 2016; Gualtieri 2004; Kayyali 2013). However, the claim that some MENA peoples, such as Syrians, were of the Asian race was challenged by a series of court cases which ultimately granted select few of them the right to naturalization (e.g., *Dow vs United States 1915* in the United States Federal Circuit Court), illustrating how tenuous and liminal these racial classifications were. Across these cases, MENA

immigrants benefited from claiming a White identity because it granted them opportunity for citizenship and relative security.

Changes in U.S. immigration policy in the 1920s restricted immigrants from geographic regions that were considered to be part of the Asian continent, including many MENA countries. This resulted in a second wave (mid-1900s) of MENA immigrants, mostly from Egypt, Iraq and Syria who were fleeing armed conflict in their country of birth. Unlike the previous wave, immigrants the second wave included a larger number of Muslims, professionals, and highly educated individuals. These restrictive immigration policies were lifted in 1965, which opened the door to a third and more diverse group of MENA immigrants, particularly from Iraq, Iran, Lebanon, and Egypt. These immigrants were largely Muslim, highly educated or in pursuit of education in the U.S., and refugees (Awad et al. 2019; Maghbouleh 2017; Zong and Batalova 2015; Ghazal Aswad 2019; Kayyali 2013).

The lived experiences of these later waves of immigrants, as well as the socio-political environment of the time, was vastly different from the first wave of Christian MENA immigrants. Many Muslim immigrants, and their U.S.-born or immigrant children, had visible characteristics, such as skin color, hair color, or traditions of dress, as well as religious practices that signaled an "otherness" and limited their options for racial identification (Read 2008; Waters 1990, 1996). Simultaneously, growing political tensions between the U.S. and some MENA countries in the 1960s and 1970s further ostracized many U.S.-born and MENA immigrants from mainstream White American culture (Cainkar 2016; Maghbouleh 2017). Therefore, unlike earlier waves of MENA immigrants, the relevance of a White racial classification or recognition and acceptance became increasingly diminished.

Today's *de jure* racial classification of MENA Americans (inclusive of US-born and immigrant peoples of MENA ancestry) as White directly challenges the *de facto* lived racialization and discrimination many within the MENA community experience (Awad et al. 2019; Cainkar 2008; Hakim & Branscombe, 2023; Kayyali 2013; Maghbouleh 2017). Some scholars argue that persons of MENA descent "do not benefit from the statuses, assumptions, and rewards that accrue to whiteness" (Cainkar 2008, p. 63). Similarly, this group is often represented negatively in the media and in movies, particularly after events such as the Iranian Hostage Crisis and the attack on September 11, 2001 (Alsultany 2008; Kia-Keating 2021; Maghbouleh 2017; Naber 2000; Shaheen 2001, 2008; Suad et al. 2008). The terms "Middle Eastern", "Arab", and "Muslim" are often mistakenly conflated with "terrorist" and these groups are erroneously portrayed as hypervisible racialized and un-American enemies of the U.S. (Cainkar 2008; Mohamed 2021; Naber 2000; Pew Forum on Religion & Public Life 2010). The concurrent invisibility and hypervisibility of MENA individuals creates a unique tension in their racial identity, and validation of these experiences is a key contributor to social, emotional, physical, and economic well-being (Awad et al. 2019; Hakim & Branscombe, 2023; Jetten et al., 2015; Greenaway et al., 2015). These historical undercurrents led to campaigns in advance of the 2010 Census from the MENA community encouraging individuals not to report their race as White with the campaign "Check it Right, You Ain't White" popularized by Arab American activists (CNN 2010). Similarly, many MENA individuals and community groups advocated for the inclusion of a distinct MENA racial category for the 2020 Census (reviewed in Kayyali 2013; Matthews et al. 2017).

Factors Predicting MENA Racial Identification

This historical lens highlights the socially constructed nature of race and reveals how at the individual level, racial self-identification may reflect not only a person's ethnic attachment, religion, and immigration history, but also their lived experiences negotiating how they relate to the existing sociopolitical context of racial hierarchies in the U.S. (Abdulrahim 2008; Ajrouch & Jamal 2007; Kulczycki & Lobo 2014; Waters 1996). As such, the lived experiences of many MENA Americans are strikingly different than other Federally-defined White groups in the United States, such as people of European descent. For instance, one study found that 84% of MENA Americans identify as part of an ethnic minority (Awad et al. 2021). Still, given the vast diversity within the MENA population in the U.S., it is critical to examine the factors that constrain racial identity, as this pattern of self-identification may not pertain to all persons of MENA descent. In doing so, we use a systems-based view of racial identity formation that fuses psycho-sociological perspectives and accounts for individual-level, demographic characteristics to cultural variations based on ancestry and broad ecological factors in the social context individuals are embedded in.

Demographic and socioeconomic characteristics play an important role in racial self-identification. A study of Arab Americans in the Detroit metropolitan area showed that 64% of the 1,000 participants self-identified as White and the remaining one-third of participants identified as "other" when there was no other relevant racial category to select (e.g., "MENA") (Shryock 2008). The persons more likely to identify as White were U.S. born, older, educated, or living in middle-class suburbs (Ajrouch and Jamal 2007; Shryock 2008). In addition, having a Lebanese or Syrian background, and identifying as "Arab American," were associated with a higher likelihood of reporting as White (Ajrouch and Jamal 2007), whereas darker perceived complexions, experiences with discrimination, and being Muslim were strong predictors of

selecting a non-White, "other" race (Hakim & Branscombe, 2023). Qualitative research on children of Lebanese immigrants in Dearborn, Michigan found that respondents categorize their peers into two groups: "boaters" who have not adopted American cultural habits and have limited English proficiency and "whites" who have access to education, privilege, and wealth (Ajrouch 2000). These findings suggest persons of MENA ancestry with higher levels of educational attainment, English proficiency, and income, may be more likely to report their race as White, much like other liminal racial/ethnic groups such as peoples of Hispanic origin (e.g., Wilton et al. 2013).

Treatment by the host society and how one is perceived by others are additional factors that may influence racial identity. Recent in-lab experimental research showed that racially ambiguous simulated faces were classified as less so as White on a continuous scale when they were labelled as belonging to someone of MENA descent rather than European descent, despite the faces being physically identical (Chaney et al. 2021). In an ethnographic study of Arab Muslims in Chicago, almost two-thirds of participants said that Arabs were not White and the most frequent reason participants provided for this response was because of the discriminatory treatment Arabs received from individuals in American society and its institutions (Cainkar 2008). Approximately half of the study participants also reported experiencing some form of discrimination after the events of September 11, 2001 (i.e., 9/11), which only served to exacerbate growing anti-Arab, anti-Muslim, and anti-MENA sentiments in the U.S. (Jones 2001).

Differences in religious affiliation are also associated with racial identification. While persons of MENA descent practice a range of religious ideologies, including Islam, Judaism, Christianity, Hinduism, Buddhism, Folk religions, as well as no religious affiliation, the majority

of previous research has specifically compared the experiences of Muslims and Christians, the two largest religious groups in the MENA region (Pew Research Center, 2015), A study among MENA individuals found that Muslims were more likely to report experiencing discrimination and that others were more likely to perceive them as not White compared to their Christian counterparts (Read 2008; see also Maghbouleh et al., 2022). Additional research on Arab Americans in the Detroit metropolitan area found that Muslims themselves were less likely to identify as white compared to Christians (Ajrouch and Jamal 2007; Shryock 2008; Hakim & Branscombe, 2023). Similarly, while religion plays an equally central role for Muslim and Christian Arabs, Muslim Arabs reported more negative public regard of their religion and more experiences of discrimination than Christian Arabs (Hashem & Awad 2021). According to some polls, the majority of the American population knows little to nothing about Islam and has no Muslim acquaintances. These same sources found that assaults against Muslim, MENA, and Arab people grow each year (Kishi 2017; Pew Research Center, 2011). Among U.S. adults, 39% acknowledge there is "a lot of" discrimination against Muslims, a number which exceeds that of other religious minority groups (Mohamed 2021; Pew Research Center, 2017).

For MENA immigrants, time in the U.S., and the interplay between their distinct heritage and host cultures plays an important role in shaping individual-level racial identification (Alba & Nee 1997; Berry, 1992; Gordon 1964; Haller et al. 2011; Ozer, 2017; Portes & Rumbaut 1996, 2001; Portes & Zhou 1993). According to classic psychological theories of acculturation, such as the fourfold acculturation strategies (Berry, 1992), contact between heritage and host cultures can result in individuals orienting to one dominant culture (assimilation, separation), orienting toward both cultures (biculturalism), or rejecting both cultures altogether (marginalization). Regarding racial identification, once in the U.S., first-generation MENA immigrants are often

faced with negotiating the Federal racial categories when interacting with the decennial Census, demographic surveys, and other Federal forms and programs. Some recent immigrants may continue to primarily identify by kinship, religious sect, ethnic group, or other affiliation based on their heritage culture, choosing not to respond to the race question or reporting as Some Other Race because they do not relate to the categories offered, they do not feel accepted in U.S. society, or they fear retaliation for disclosing a stigmatized identity (Abdulrahim 2008; Cainkar 2008; Carroll et al. 2011; Hakim & Branscombe, 2023; Maghbouleh 2017; Naber 2000; Read 2008). Others may adopt the host culture's classification of MENA as White because that is how they view themselves, or they may report as White because the Federal government defines them as such or because they want to receive protection from a White identity (Abdulrahim 2008; Carroll et al. 2011; Hakim & Branscombe, 2023). On the whole, MENA immigrants do seem to demonstrate cultural integration in the U.S., marked by their high rates of marriage to non-MENA partners -- over 70% of MENA males and over 60% of MENA females -- which increase in subsequent generations (Bakhtiari & Sohoni 2021; Dallo et al. 2008; Kulczycki & Lobo 2002, 2014; Waters 1996). However, these experiences vary within the MENA community, with some later generation MENA Americans orienting more to White American behaviors and traits than their immigrant parents (e.g., straight line assimilation) whereas in other cases, the children of immigrants deliberately orient to preserve their heritage culture and values (e.g., Gans, 1992; Maghbouleh, 2017; Mokadi & Youssef, 2022). To some extent, the racial identity of MENA Americans and the differences in characteristics between those who identify as white and those who identify as other races may indicate the extent to which they feel integrated within mainstream U.S. society (Ajrouch & Jamal 2007).

Maghbouleh and colleagues (2022) recently examined a myriad of factors related to perceptions of MENA racial identity among MENA and non-MENA peoples. Hundreds of online participants were tasked with ethnoracially classifying randomized profiles (based on name, religion, language, occupation, skin color, and ancestry) in two experimental conditions: when a distinct MENA category was present vs. absent. Results indicated that certain traits were associated with a distinct MENA racial categorization, particularly ancestry, first names, and languages spoken, and these patterns were consistent among people who self-identified as MENA and among non-MENA white individuals. Altogether, the past two decades of research on MENA racial identity indicate the vast diversity among peoples of MENA descent. Still, there are also many shared similarities -- beyond mere geographic proximity -- including aspects of their cultural practices and how they are perceived by other groups that contribute toward a growing convergence around a shared identity (Awad et al. 2019).

Convergence Around a MENA Identity

Pan-ethnic labels such as “Arab American”, “MENA”, and “SWANA” emerged in the U.S. as an ethno-political response to the convergence of various forces taking place in the MENA community (Naber 2000; SWANA Alliance n.d.). While the Arab-Israeli war of 1967 heightened ethno-political consciousness among groups of MENA origin, the cultural environment in American society in the late 1960s facilitated the dynamics of ethnic revival, including within the MENA community (Zogby 1990; Aswad & Bilge 1996; Lin & Jamal 1997). In contrast, increased socio-political stigmatization after 9/11 led to some individuals of MENA ancestry distancing themselves from an Arab or Middle Eastern identity due to fears of stigma (Carroll et al. 2011; Cainkar 2002). However, those who felt further alienated by the erroneous narrative of MENA as “radicalized Muslims” or “terrorists” that emerged in post-9/11 discourse,

strengthened their MENA identity and distanced themselves from a White identity (Abdulrahim 2008; Read 2008). Across these decades, the MENA community experienced social and political marginalization, as the media portrayed them as a monolithic group at odds with the West (Abraham 1989; Kia-Keating 2021; Suleiman & Abu-Laban 1989), and individual MENA Americans were blamed for political tensions between the U.S. and their home country (Maghbouleh 2017). It was under these circumstances that some individuals of MENA ancestry who used to identify by country of origin, religion, or as "American" came together and converged under these pan-ethnic labels (Naber 2000).

U.S. Federal Policy on MENA Racial Classification

The role of the U.S. Census Bureau is to accurately capture the changing demographic dynamics of the American social fabric, including racial identity, which is an ever-changing construct. Since the first decennial census in 1790, which only contained three racial categories, to the 2020 Census, where multiple detailed checkboxes, examples, and write-in response areas were presented to respondents, including the use of a "Some Other Race" category (Marks & Ríos-Vargas, 2021), the wording for the racial identity question has changed in some way each decade (Pratt, 2021). These changes reveal how the very definition of race is socially dependent. Continuing this tradition, recent attention to the complexity of MENA identity from scholars, activists, and other MENA community members (reviewed in Kayyali 2013) led the Census Bureau to test the inclusion of a distinct MENA category in research leading up to the 2020 Census.

In 2015, the Census Bureau launched the 2015 National Content Test to examine the inclusion of a separate MENA category on the 2020 Census, as well as other content changes, motivated by focus group feedback from the 2010 Census Alternative Questionnaire Experiment

(AQE) Research on Race and Hispanic Origin (Compton et al., 2012; Matthews et al. 2017). This study of 1.2 million housing units across the U.S suggested that the inclusion of a dedicated MENA category was viewed favorably among MENA individuals and, critically, increased data quality. When a separate MENA category was available, nearly 79% of MENA-identifying individuals (i.e., those who wrote in a MENA detailed origin response in any write-in field) checked that box. The number of respondents indicating Some Other Race declined from 11.5% (absence of MENA category) to 3% (presence of MENA category) (Matthews et al. 2017). Moreover, there was substantially higher consistency in respondents who identified as MENA in the initial survey and the reinterview when the question design featured a distinct MENA category (70.4%) than when it did not (16.1%) (Matthews et al. 2017). The conclusion from the National Content Test report was that a dedicated MENA response category, presented on a combined race and ethnicity question, was the optimal design for improving race and ethnicity data, which other reports have also concluded (e.g., Maghbouleh et al., 2022). More broadly, these results indicated the unique liminality and variability in MENA racial self-identification in the presence and absence of a distinct MENA category (see also Maghbouleh et al., 2022).

The Census Bureau, however, does not make a unilateral decision on the content of the Decennial Census, and, ultimately, any changes must be reviewed and approved by OMB and the United States Congress in time to be implemented. Updates to Directive 15 by OMB were not made in time to move forward with an updated optimal design for the 2020 Census, including the addition of a distinct MENA category, and on January 26, 2018, the Census Bureau announced that the 2020 Census would continue to use the existing two-question design without a separate MENA category (Fontenot, 2018). Thus, per the 1997 OMB standards, MENA responses are still classified as part of the White racial category. Nevertheless, due to the

addition of a write-in box under the White category starting in 2020, detailed MENA responses were elicited, collected, and coded for the first time and have started to be publicly disseminated (Marks & Ríos-Vargas, 2021; Marks et al., 2023).

In June of 2022, OMB announced they were convening an interagency working group to conduct a formal review to revise the Federal standards for race and ethnicity data (The White House, 2022). In January 2023, this group published an initial set of recommended revisions for the race and ethnicity standards, including a proposed recommendation for a distinct response category for MENA (Initial Proposals for Updating OMB's Race and Ethnicity Statistical Standards, 2023). As of April 27, 2023, the working group reported 20,255 public comments regarding the revisions to the 1997 standards for Federal race and ethnicity data – and many individuals and community groups have voiced their support for the proposed addition of a distinct MENA category. In anticipation of expected revisions to Directive 15 set to be announced by the summer of 2024, the findings of this study provide empirical support for the working group's initial proposal and the public's continued advocacy for a distinct MENA category.

Contributions of the Present Study

In this study, we aim to overcome the limited understanding of racial identification among the MENA population in the U.S. To achieve this, we use a large, nationally representative dataset containing the *unedited* race responses of persons identified as having MENA ancestry in the American Community Survey (ACS) conducted by the U.S. Census Bureau from 2005 to 2019. In doing so, we examine the share of respondents who racially identify as White versus a group that is not White, thus underlining the diversity of racial identities in the MENA population. Moreover, we test a multi-explanatory system of factors that

predict racial identification, and we demonstrate the unique contribution of immigrant acculturation on predicting racial identification for some of these factors. In addition, while our research is separate from past Census Bureau and ongoing Federal efforts to evaluate improvements to the quality of race and ethnicity data (e.g., Mathews et al. 2017; Initial Proposals for Updating OMB's Race and Ethnicity Statistical Standards, 2023), our findings may contribute to this critical evaluation.

METHODS

Data

The American Community Survey

We use data from the American Community Survey (ACS), an annual, nationally representative survey of the socioeconomic and housing characteristics of the U.S. population conducted by the U.S. Census Bureau. Each year, the ACS targets 1% of the total population and samples both housing units and group quarters (e.g., college dorm, nursing home). In this analysis, we examine ACS responses from the first full sample in 2005 through to 2019. We selected this date range due to question design changes to the separate race question in the 2020 ACS that may have affected our findings, particularly the addition of a dedicated White write-in box as well as the inclusion of Lebanese and Egyptian as examples to the White category[2]. This research was approved by the Census Bureau to examine unedited 2005-2019 ACS data, which includes unedited responses to the race question (i.e., before they are edited according to the Federal standards), which we describe more in the following section.

[2] While Lebanese and Egyptian are listed as examples of detailed groups within the White racial category, results from the 2010 Alternative Questionnaire Experiment on Race and Ethnicity indicated that "Many participants across focus groups felt that the inclusion of the examples of Egyptian and Lebanese with the White racial category was 'wrong' or 'inaccurate.' "(Compton et al., 2012). These respondents suggested Egyptian and Lebanese should be used as examples for a separate MENA or Arab category.

How we identified the MENA population in the ACS. The geographic boundaries of the MENA region are ambiguous and often vary based on source. In this work, we aim for a broad working definition of MENA countries, regions, and ethnic groups by blending definitions offered by the U.S. Census Bureau, United Nations Statistical Division, and existing scholarly work in this domain (e.g., Maghbouleh et al., 2022). For our analysis, classification of MENA was based on the ACS Ancestry question (the wording of this question is available in Appendix Figure A). Specifically, we defined MENA to include all peoples of Armenian, Algerian, Alhucemas, Arab or Arabic, Assyrian/Chaldean/Syriac, Bahraini, Bedouin, Berber, Egyptian, Emirati, Iranian, Iraqi, Israeli, Jordanian, Kurdish, Kuria Muria Islander, Kuwaiti, Lebanese, Libyan, Mauritanian, Middle Eastern, Moroccan, Muscat, North African, Omani, Palestinian, Qatari, Rio De Oro, Saudi Arabian, Syrian, Trucial States, Tunisian, Turkish, and/or Yemeni ancestry. This working definition slightly differs from the U.S. Census Bureau's 2015 National Content Test, which did not include Armenian or Turkish ancestries in the definition of MENA, though the report notes that some stakeholder feedback was in favor of including these ancestries in the MENA classification. By including these ancestries in our expanded definition, our goal was to cast a wide net to gather a MENA sample that honors the vast diversity in ancestry, ethnicity, language, nationality, religion, and physical appearance of this region. Indeed, public comments on the 2023 proposed revisions to Directive 15 highlight that many people of Armenian ancestry do see themselves as a part of the MENA community.

Analytic sample. In preparing our sample, we omitted responses from group quarters, thus retaining only respondents from housing units. Our analyses included people who reported at least one of the MENA ancestries listed above. There were approximately 607,400 individuals that were identified as MENA through their responses to the ACS ancestry question in at least

one of the years 2005-2019.[3] Among this sample, 2,900 individuals did not report a race and were therefore excluded from our analyses, leaving us with an analytic sample of 604,500.

Measures

Unedited Racial Identification

In this study, we analyzed restricted-use data that have not been edited to conform to the Federal standards on race and ethnicity set by OMB. The ACS race question includes checkbox categories for White, Black, American Indian or Alaska Native (AIAN), Some Other Race, as well as seven detailed Asian groups and four detailed Native Hawaiian or Other Pacific Islander (NHPI) groups[4]. For these years of the ACS, there are also dedicated write-in areas provided for the AIAN category, for the Other Asian / Other Pacific Islander checkbox, and for the Some Other Race category. These write-in response areas allow individuals to write in their specific tribe or detailed racial identity. The wording of the race question on the 2019 ACS is available in Appendix Figure A.

In our analyses, the dependent variable included three unordered race categories for White, Some Other Race, and all other responses. Individuals were counted as White or as Some Other Race only if they marked the appropriate single checkboxes. We created an "all other responses" group by combining the single-race checkboxes for Black, AIAN, Asian, and NHPI; any multiracial response (i.e., the individual selected multiple checkbox categories across minimum category definitions); and write-in only responses (i.e., the individual provided at least one write-in response but did not select a checkbox category). We chose to make a distinction between individuals reporting as Some Other Race and those identifying with other responses

[3] If an individual was a respondent in multiple years of the ACS, we used the most recent response in our analysis.
[4] The ACS race question offers seven Asian checkbox categories (Asian Indian, Chinese, Filipino, Japanese, Korean, Vietnamese, and Other Asian) and four NHPI checkbox categories (Native Hawaiian, Guamanian or Chamorro, Samoan, and Other Pacific Islander).

that were not White because the former may reflect respondents' assessment that none of the listed racial categories is adequate for them.

Independent Variables

The ACS contains several questions which conceptually cover a variety of population characteristics, which in this study we leverage to predict racial identification among MENA respondents. Among categorical predictors, reference levels were selected in numerical order (e.g., the lowest median household income bin) or for substantive reasons (e.g., we expected differences in responses to the 2010 ACS compared to other years due to activist campaigns; Lebanese was the largest detailed ancestry group in the sample). Sample characteristics for all predictors are provided in Appendix Table A.

Demographic Predictors. We included as demographic predictors age, sex, languages spoken at home (English proficiency and use of other languages), educational attainment of the householder, median household income, and housing tenure. Age was treated categorically into the following groups: Less than 18 years, 18 to 24 years, 25 to 44 years (reference level), 45 to 64 years, and 65 years and older. The reference level for age was set based on the largest age group size. Sex was defined as male (reference level) or female. Languages spoken at home is measured for household members who are five years or older. To retain all other information for householders below five years old, we added a missing response option for language knowledge, which resulted in four levels of this variable: English only (reference level), English and other language (high English proficiency), English and other language (low English proficiency), and not answered. Educational attainment of the householder ranged from less than high school (reference level) to high school/GED/some college, and Bachelor's degree or higher. Median household income was also binned to the following groups: less than $25,000 (reference level),

$25,000 to $49,999, $50,000 to $74,999, $75,000 to $99,999, $100,000 to $124,999, and $125,000 or more. Housing tenure was defined as owner (reference level) or renter.

Ancestry and Nativity Predictors. We measured both whether an individual has a mixed ancestral background and their specific or detailed MENA ancestry. Our mixed ancestry variable indicates if a person reported only MENA ancestries (reference level) or if they reported both MENA and non-MENA ancestries. Detailed MENA ancestry[5] was binned into the following groups: Lebanese (reference level), Armenian, Assyrian/Chaldean/Syriac, Iranian, Israeli, Turkish, Syrian, Egyptian, Palestinian, Jordanian, Moroccan, Iraqi, Arab/Arabic, and other MENA. The "Other MENA" category includes Algerian, Libyan, Tunisian, Berber, Bahraini, Kuwaiti, Saudi Arabian, Yemeni, Omani, Qatari, Kurdish, and Emirati, as well as any general ancestries like "Middle Eastern" or "North African" (these groups were too small to analyze on their own). Lebanese was selected as the reference level because it was the largest detailed ancestry group in the sample.

We also examined place of birth and immigration duration. We compare people who are U.S.-born (reference level) to people who immigrated to the United States more than 20 years before being surveyed, 10-19 before being surveyed, and less than 10 years before being surveyed.

Household and Contextual Predictors. We examined variables related to the household and regional context of respondents. We calculated the percentage of all household members who are not White (including people who identified as Hispanic or Latino), which we refer to as percent household racial minority. We also examined the percent of people with MENA ancestry

[5] Two responses to the ancestry question are coded. If only one MENA response was provided, then that response was assigned to detailed ancestry. If both responses were MENA, then we assigned detailed ancestry as the first MENA response reported. For example, if an individual reported Lebanese and Egyptian, then we assigned the detailed ancestry group as Lebanese.

in the residing county and Census region of residence. Percent household racial minority and percent MENA in county were treated continuously. Census regions are four standardized geographical groupings of the continental U.S.: West (reference level), Northeast, Midwest, and South.

ACS Survey Administration Predictors. Variables related to the logistics of administering the ACS included year of ACS survey and ACS response mode. We included survey year as an independent variable because during the 2010 Census, activists organized campaigns encouraging individuals of MENA ancestry to not identify as White, with the slogan "Check it right; you ain't white!" (CNN 2010). This campaign may have influenced race reporting of MENA individuals in the ACS in 2010 and in later years. Therefore, we set 2010 as the reference level for this categorical variable to examine potential differences due to this targeted campaigning. We also examined potential differences between mail or internet response type from other modes involving an interviewer.[6] The presence of an interviewer may affect a respondent's response to the ACS race question. For example, although interviewers are trained otherwise, an interviewer's personal opinion or interpretation of the race categories may affect their presentation of the question to respondents and the respondent's answers. This variable was coded as mail or Internet responses (reference level) vs. other response modes.

Analytic Approach

First, we show unadjusted descriptive statistics of the unedited racial groups reported by MENA respondents to the ACS, including White, Some Other Race, and all other responses. We show both weighted and unweighted estimates. Weighted counts adjust for nationally representative person-level weights on the basis of several core demographic traits in order to

[6] Other modes include Computer Assisted Telephone Interviews and Computer Assisted Personal Interviews.

bring the characteristics of the sample more into alignment with the total population (Alexander, Dahl, & Weidman, 1997).

Second, we use multinomial logistic regressions to model the demographic, cultural, socioeconomic, and contextual factors that are associated with race reporting of MENA individuals. The dependent variable includes three unedited race categories for White, Some Other Race, and all other responses.

Third, we repeat these multinomial logistic models but split the analytic sample into three subsamples to test whether the predictors of race reporting differ for U.S.-born MENA respondents and MENA immigrants, and we further conduct a median split among MENA immigrants based on number of years in the U.S. For this analysis, we collapse across our initial immigration duration groups to simply compare shorter-term from longer-term immigrants based on roughly equal group sizes. Sample characteristics broken down by nativity and time in the U.S. are provided in Appendix Table C.

RESULTS

Overall Race Response

Table 1 and Figure 1 show the distribution of unedited race responses of persons of MENA ancestry. Most people with MENA ancestry marked the White checkbox only, 73.4% of the unweighted count and 72% of the weighted count. However, over a quarter of respondents did not select the White only checkbox. The second most common response was Some Other Race with 14.3% of the unweighted count and 16.5% of the weighted count. Finally, the remainder reported another single race or multiple race responses, which we group under the "all other responses" category (11.8% of the unweighted sample, 11% of the weighted sample). Of note, the largest change between the unweighted and weighted samples was observed in a trade-off between White and Some Other Race responses. Accounting for nationally representative demographic weights resulted in a 2.2 percentage point increase in Some Other Race responding and a 1.4 percentage point decrease in white-only responses. Less than one percent of persons in our restricted data did not report a race, 0.5% of the unweighted count and 0.4% of the weighted count.

Table 1 also illustrates the specific responses that we aggregated into the all other responses category. Over half of these responses were due to multiple checkboxes selected (50.8%). The remainder involved a single checkbox (36.8%) or no checkbox at all (12.4%). Of single checkbox responses, the majority selected Asian, which is consistent with past reports that some MENA may self-identify as Asian, rather than white, because many Middle Eastern countries are geographically situated on the Asian continent (Maghbouleh 2020). Moreover, we note that unlike some studies (e.g., Maghbouleh et al., 2022), our definition of MENA excluded the Northeast African ancestries, Sudanese, Somali, and Djiboutians. These ancestries are coded

as Black by the U.S. Census Bureau, which may have affected the pattern of results observed here. Indeed, respondents with these ancestries were found to report as Black in the 2015 NCT (Matthews et al., 2017).

Factors Predicting Overall Race Responses

Figure 2 shows odds ratios from the multinomial regression analysis (unweighted) testing how various characteristics of the respondent and their environment predict racial response. As this figure represents odds ratios, a coefficient greater than 1 indicates a higher likelihood of the given racial response type (i.e., Some Other Race or other responses) over a White racial response, whereas a coefficient less than 1 indicates a greater likelihood of a White racial response over the others (the lightly shaded portion of the graph). The specific values of these coefficients are provided in Appendix Table B.

In general, we found that, consistent with prior research, persons more likely to identify as White were older, U.S. born, monolingual English speakers, and more affluent (Ajrouch and Jamal 2007). Individuals more likely to identify as Some Other Race, in contrast, tended to be younger, foreign born, speak their ancestral language at home, and live in households and counties with other MENA or minority individuals. We discuss these results in greater detail in what follows.

Demographic Characteristics. Consistent with findings from previous research, individuals aged 45 and older were more likely to identify as white than as either Some Other Race or all other responses compared to younger individuals (Ajrouch and Jamal 2007; Shryock 2008). Older people had higher odds of identifying as Some Other Race or all other responses than white compared to younger people. In terms of sex, females were slightly more likely to identify as white than Some Other Race or all other responses compared to males.

Linguistic and educational characteristics also played an influential role in racial identification (Ajrouch and Jamal 2007; Shryock 2008). Those who reported speaking a language other than English at home, or presumed bilinguals, were more likely to respond as Some Other Race or all other race responses, and this likelihood increased for those who were dominant in a language other than English (i.e., low English proficiency). In general, individuals living with householders with higher levels of education were more likely to identify as white compared to those living with less educated householders.

Socioeconomic traits were also related to racial response. More affluent households were more likely to report white than Some Other Race or all other responses, as compared to individuals in low-income households. Similarly, homeowners were more likely to report as white than renters.

Ancestry and Nativity. We found significant differences in racial identification patterns based on different aspects of ancestry. Those of mixed ancestry were more likely to identify as white rather than Some Other Race or all other responses compared to those who reported only MENA ancestries.

We also observed interesting differences in self-response based on detailed MENA ancestry. Those who reported their ancestry as Arab or Arabic, Egyptian, Palestinian,

Assyrian/Chaldean/Syriac, Moroccan, Jordanian, Iranian, Iraqi or other MENA (including Algerian, Libyan, Tunisian, Berber, Bahraini, Kuwaiti, Saudi Arabian, Yemeni, Omani, Qatari, Kurdish, Emirati, Middle Eastern or North African) were more likely to identify as Some Other Race or give all other responses than to report as White than persons of Lebanese ancestry (the reference level based on group size). In contrast, compared to those of Lebanese ancestry, individuals of Israeli ancestry were more likely to identify as White than Some Other Race or give all other responses. People of Armenian, Turkish, and Syrian ancestry were more likely to give all other responses than to identify as either white or Some Other Race.

Moreover, people who immigrated to the U.S. but had spent more than 10 years in the U.S., were more likely to select Some Other Race or all other racial responses compared to White than those who were born in the U.S. Conversely, people who immigrated to the U.S. but had spent less than 10 years in the U.S. were more likely to select all other responses, while they were less likely to select Some Other Race than White.

Contextual Influences. Characteristics of the household and broader community also related to how respondents indicated their race. A greater percentage of co-residents who reported identities other than White correlated with a greater likelihood of selecting Some Other Race or all other responses compared to White. We also found differences in racial identification by geographic context. Living in a county with a large MENA population was associated with an increase in the odds of reporting as Some Other Race and all other responses[7]. Regionally, individuals residing in the Northeast, Midwest, or South were more likely to report as White than those living in the West.

[7] The odds ratio for percent MENA residents in county is notably large. This is likely due to outlier counties present in the sample (i.e., some counties have a very high MENA density whereas others may have virtually no MENA residents).

Survey Factors. The year of the survey and the mode of data collection were also associated with differences in racial identification among individuals of MENA ancestry net of other factors. We found that compared to respondents in 2010 – the year of widespread messaging campaigns encouraging race responding as not White during the 2010 Census – people who responded in all other years were less likely to select Some Other Race. In later years of the ACS, the likelihood of indicating all other responses also decreased.[8]

In terms of mode of data collection, individuals who required survey follow-up contacts from interviewers in order to collect their responses, as compared to those who self-responded by mail or internet, were more likely to report as Some Other Race and less likely to report as all other responses rather than as White.

Factors Predicting Race Responses by Nativity and Time in U.S.

We further examined whether the relationships between our predictors and racial self-response varied by place of birth and time spent in the U.S. To do this, we examined odds ratios from multinomial logistic regressions for people with MENA ancestry who were born in the U.S. (52.5% of sample) and for those born outside of the U.S. (47.5% of sample) (Table 2). Thus far, we have compared three groups of immigrants based on duration in the U.S. prior to the time of survey. As can be seen in Appendix Table A, the relative size of these three immigrant groups is uneven, and it is possible the small size of the 10-19 year immigrant subgroup may lead to diminished statistical power for the large number of variables we planned to model. Thus, to maximize statistical power and examine the role of immigration duration U.S. on racial identification, we collapsed across these three levels to create two roughly equal sized groups of those born outside of the U.S. We conducted a median split among immigrants based on years in

[8] Since population size naturally increases across time, non-normalized weights in later years will reflect larger values than those in earlier years. Therefore, comparisons across time must be interpreted with caution.

the U.S. Longer-term immigrants were defined as those living in the U.S. for longer than the median number of years (17 years) at the time of the survey and shorter-term immigrants were defined as those living in the U.S. for less than that time.

In general, the results from this analysis indicate that many factors associated with racial identification impact U.S.-born, longer-term, and shorter-term immigrants in similar ways. These include demographic characteristics such as sex, whether a person is of mixed or MENA-only ancestry, as well as the percent of racial minority members in the household. However, for other experiences, particularly age, language knowledge, income, detailed ancestry, percent of MENA in the county, and region may have different associations with racial identification depending on place of birth and time spent in the U.S. We discuss these similarities and differences in greater detail below.

Demographic Characteristics. In general, we found that most demographic characteristics have similar associations with racial identification across the three groups, with a few notable exceptions. For example, across all three groups, we found that adults older than the 25 to 44 years old reference group, were more likely to report as white than as Some Other Race or all other responses but the magnitude of the odds ratios varied by time in the U.S. Among the oldest group of respondents, the odds ratio for selecting the White checkbox was largest among those born in the U.S. Among the youngest respondents (i.e., those aged 18 to 24 years), U.S.-born people of MENA ancestry were more likely to respond as White whereas those who recently immigrated to the U.S. were more likely to select Some Other Race or all other responses. In contrast, we found minimal differences across the three groups in terms of how sex predicted racial response.

Across U.S.-born and all immigrants, speaking a language other than English at home was associated with a lower likelihood of reporting as white compared to English-only speakers. The odds of U.S.-born and longer-term immigrants who speak another language at home reporting as white was smaller than shorter-term immigrants with similar linguistic traits. This was found to be particularly true among longer-term immigrants whose English proficiency was reported to be low, which may indicate sustained and strong ties to their native culture.

While higher levels of education were generally associated with higher odds of identifying as white across our three groups, household income seemed to have a different association with race reported. U.S.-born respondents across all income groups over $25,000 were more likely to identify as White than those where the householder earned less than $25,000. However, among all immigrants, higher incomes predicted a lower likelihood of identifying as White than Some Other Race responses.

Ancestry. For the most part, racial identification was associated with detailed MENA ancestry in similar ways across place of birth and time in the U.S. The only detailed MENA ancestries where the direction of racial identification was different between U.S.-born and immigrant subpopulations were from the northern MENA region, specifically Armenian and Turkish. Armenian people born in the U.S. were more likely to report as Some Other Race than White, whereas shorter-term immigrants from Armenia were more likely to report as White than Some Other Race. Turkish people born in the U.S. were similarly more likely to report as Some Other Race than White whereas all Turkish immigrants were more likely to report as White than Some Other Race.

For many detailed ancestries, including Assyrian/Chaldean/Syriac, Iranian, Iraqi, Jordanian, Egyptian, Moroccan, and Palestinian, U.S.-born respondents had the highest odds of

selecting Some Other Race or all other responses over White compared to the reference Lebanese group. While foreign-born MENA respondents were also more likely to select Some Other Race or all other responses over White, the odds of selecting Some Other Race or all other responses over white was smaller for immigrants compared to U.S.-born respondents. The linear trend with time in U.S. was not observed for respondents whose detailed ancestry was marked as Arab or one of the smaller MENA categories; instead, odds of responding as Some Other Race with time spent in the U.S. demonstrated a U-shaped pattern. Arab and other MENA respondents born in the U.S. showed the highest odds of selecting Some Other Race, followed then by shorter-term immigrants. Immigrants who lived in the U.S. greater than 17 years had the lowest odds of selecting Some Other Race over White.

Finally, we note the particularly high odds of a Some Other Race response among U.S.-born respondents of Palestinian ancestry, which was much larger in magnitude than all immigrants of Palestinian ancestry. Altogether, we observed many interesting patterns with regard to the interactive nature of ancestry and time spent in the U.S. For longer-term immigrants the effect of detailed ancestry on racial identification was sometimes more similar to U.S.-born and other times closer to that of recent immigrants. We did not observe any difference between MENA-only and mixed ancestry across the three groups.

Contextual Influences. While the internal racial composition of the household did not relate to differences in race reporting across our three groups, where people live geographically did predict race responses. Among U.S.-born respondents, the likelihood of reporting as White vs. Some Other Race or all other responses was comparable across the Northeast, Midwest, and Southern regions of the country. However, among immigrants, those living in the Northeast and South were the most likely to opt for a White racial response, regardless of time spent in the U.S.

Most notably, the presence of other MENA residents in the county on individual race reporting varied considerably across the three groups. Among U.S.-born respondents, living in a county with more MENA residents was highly associated with a Some Other Race response compared to White. However, among longer-term immigrants, the MENA composition of the county was not associated with any differential race responding. For shorter-term immigrants, living in areas with higher concentrations of MENA peoples was associated with a higher likelihood of responding as White. Together, this indicates that the racial composition of a respondent's direct environment plays a large role in predicting self-responses for people born in the U.S. but less so for immigrants, particularly longer-term immigrants.

Survey Factors. The coefficients for the year of the survey also showed differences by place of birth and time in U.S, though any changes across time should be interpreted with caution given we do not adjust for natural population changes over time. For U.S.-born respondents, we observed a general trend for the likelihood of responding as White vs. Some Other Race to decrease over years. In contrast, longer-term immigrants were more likely to select White than Some Other Race or all other responses across all years (except for 2009). Shorter-term immigrants prior to 2010 were more likely to select all other responses (but not Some Other Race) compared to White; however, in all later years they tended to select White over both Some Other Race and all other responses. This may be interpreted as the short-term effect of the campaigns leading up to the 2010 Census to increase the reporting as a group that is not White for MENA populations. We did not observe meaningful differences based on response mode across the three groups.

DISCUSSION

We explored patterns associated with the racial identification of individuals of MENA ancestry using unedited race responses from the U.S. Census Bureau's annual American Community Survey (ACS) from 2005-2019. Critically, our findings indicate that given the options available in the current race question, where there is not a dedicated MENA category, and in the context of Federal standards defining MENA groups within the White racial category, over a quarter of respondents with MENA ancestry select an option other than White alone. This suggests that people of MENA ancestry do not uniformly see themselves as White in the context of reporting on a Federal survey. Investigating potential differences among the MENA population who report White compared to those who report other races has generally not been possible with publicly available data, as Federal standards define MENA within the White racial category and detailed MENA responses are generally not tabulated. Past studies aiming to examine the racial responses of MENA peoples have been limited in sample size, which consequently limits the range of variables that can be examined at once. In leveraging the richness of data collected by the Census Bureau's American Community Survey, our research is uniquely able to contribute important insights into how demographic, socioeconomic, cultural, and contextual characteristics are associated with the racial identification of peoples of MENA ancestry.

Overall MENA Race Responses

The first important takeaway from this research is that over 25% of ACS respondents of MENA ancestry between 2005-2019 did not select the White checkbox alone, despite the official classification of MENA peoples as White. Of those who did not select the White checkbox alone, the majority selected the Some Other Race checkbox. The Some Other Race option was

initially created to be a small residual category but has grown from the third largest racial response category in 2000 to the second largest racial response category in 2020. Experts at the U.S. Census Bureau state that the growth in Some Other Race responses over time may be predominantly based on some people not identifying themselves within the existing set of OMB racial categories (U.S. Census Bureau, 2022). While the majority of Some Other Race responses tend to be Hispanic peoples, some MENA responses (i.e., Some Other Race checkbox with no write-in) are also contributing to this trend.

Of all the other single checkbox responses, respondents of MENA ancestry predominantly selected the Other Asian checkbox. Qualitative evidence from past research indicates that people of Middle Eastern ancestry may opt for an Asian racial response given the geographic location of their ancestral country/region on the Asian continent. Past evidence further indicates that most of these respondents are aware that they do not fit within the bounds of what would be considered a "typical" Asian race (i.e., East Asian, South Asian), yet they see Asian as the closest option to capture their non-White lived experiences (Maghbouleh 2020).

We implemented person-level survey weights from the ACS to examine the response rates of our sample when it more closely matches the demographic traits of the country as a whole. Doing so slightly decreased the proportion of respondents who select the White checkbox and slightly increases the proportion of respondents who select Some Other Race. This could indicate that people who are more likely to identify as groups other than White may be undersampled. Our analysis is not intended to provide insight on the relative size of the MENA population across the U.S. According to public data released by the U.S. Census Bureau, over 3 million persons of MENA ancestry lived in the U.S. in 2019 (U.S. Census Bureau, 2019), and a recent U.S. Census Bureau report using newly available detailed MENA information revealed

that approximately 3.5 million people indicated a MENA response to the race question on the 2020 Census (Marks et al., 2023). This shows that the estimated size of the MENA population is close to that of other minimum categories for Native Hawaiians and Other Pacific Islanders and for American Indians and Alaska Natives.

Taken together, a sizeable portion of respondents of MENA ancestry do not see their identity reflected among the minimum OMB racial categories presented on the ACS, and instead opt for the residual Some Other Race category or identify within the broader classification of Asian. Indeed, this finding is consistent with the U.S. Census Bureau's own internal testing of race responses among MENA-identifying people, which concluded that inclusion of a dedicated MENA category substantially reduced Some Other Race response rates and provided more consistent race reporting (Matthews et al. 2017).

A System of Factors Predict MENA Racial Identity

The second important takeaway from this research is that MENA racial identity formation is influenced by a dynamic system of factors, ranging from demographic characteristics, ancestral and cultural backgrounds, contextual factors, and survey-related constraints in survey response. Given the size of the MENA community in the United States, past research has used relatively small sample sizes or focused on subgroups within the broader MENA category, which has limited the number of factors that can be simultaneously examined (e.g., Ajrouch and Jamal 2007; Cainkar 2008; Compton et al. 2012; Shryock 2008, c.f. Maghbouleh et al., 2022).

Overall, we found that people of MENA ancestry who were older, male, spoke only English at home, reported higher levels of education, and were more affluent have a greater likelihood of reporting their racial identity as White compared to Some Other Race or all other

responses. Our results converge with past research conducted on smaller samples or subpopulations within the MENA community (e.g., Arabs), as well as other U.S. liminal racial/ethnic groups (Ajrouch 2000; Ajrouch and Jamal 2007; Hakim & Branscombe, 2023; Shryock 2008; Wilton et al. 2013). For instance, Hakim and Branscombe (2023) reported that Arab Americans living in Detroit were also less likely to identify as not White with age. Other research points to a similar association between traditional markers of assimilation, such as language, education, wealth, and homeownership, to notions of whiteness in the context of Arabs living in the U.S. (Ajrouch and Jamal 2007). Our research expands these patterns of results related to demographic characteristics more broadly to also include non-Arab national and ethnic communities from the MENA region (e.g., Kurds, Iranians)

We observe interesting patterns of racial identification based on ancestry. People with a mixed MENA and non-MENA ancestry were more likely to select the White checkbox than people with MENA-only ancestry. This result is consistent with the findings from Maghbouleh et al., (2023), who also reported that full MENA ancestries were observed as less likely White than full European ancestries or even mixed MENA-European ancestries.

Similarly, the geographic placement of a respondent's detailed ancestry also related to racial identification. Ancestries from the Northwestern area of the MENA region (i.e., Armenian, Israeli, Syrian, and Turkish), were more likely to identify as White, while most other ancestries are more likely to report as a group other than White than Lebanese, including Assyrian/Chaldean/Syriac, Arab or Arabic, Egyptian, Jordanian, Iranian, Iraqi, Moroccan, Palestinian, and other MENA ancestries that we grouped together due to small sample sizes. These results are consistent with the work of Ajrouch and Jamal (2007) who reported that people with Lebanese or Syrian background are more likely to identify as White compared to those with

origins in Yemen or Iraq. It may be that differences in phenotype and skin color, as well as religious affiliation, make these groups more likely to identify as not White in the United States. Specifically, Egypt, Jordan, Morocco, Iran, Iraq, and the countries that comprise the other MENA group are all Muslim-majority countries (Pew Research Center, 2011). As mentioned earlier, assimilation for MENA immigrants who are Muslim may be more complex and they are more limited in their options for racial identification compared to Christians (Read 2008; Waters 1990, 1996). Furthermore, these results highlight the dual heterogeneity-homogeneity across the MENA community. While there is meaningful and vast diversity among members of the MENA community, there is also unity and shared experience.

These results are also consistent with findings of the U.S. Census Bureau's own testing of racial identification among people of MENA background in the United States, which further highlight the abundant diversity within MENA communities. The 2015 National Content Test, which examined racial response patterns when a distinct MENA category was present or absent, revealed that some MENA groups were more likely to report under the new MENA category than others. The report showed that about one-third or more of the respondents who identified as Lebanese, Arab, Assyrian, Israeli or used pan-ethnic terms (Middle Eastern, North African) provided their detailed group under the White category instead of the MENA category. In contrast, 75% or more of respondents who identified as Algerian, Iraqi, Iranian, Egyptian, Jordanian, Libyan, Moroccan, Palestinian and Saudi Arabian identified under the MENA category (Mathews et al. 2017). While our results here cannot speak to racial identification behavior in the presence of a distinct MENA category, they do indicate that a non-trivial proportion (>25%) of all respondents with MENA ancestry, who are classified as White within

current Federal standards, do not select the White alone checkbox for their self-identification, particularly Egyptians and Iranians (Appendix Table A).

In addition to factors related to the self (e.g., age, sex, ancestry), the broader social environment is associated with racial identification. Living in a household with individuals who identify as a group other than White, in a county with a large MENA population, or in the racially diverse West region of the U.S. all increased the odds of not identifying as White. Altogether, these results are cohesive with the notion that individuals embedded in racially diverse contexts, where the share of groups other than White community members is large, are more likely to not select a White identity for themselves. Other research on multiracial adolescents has found a similar role for social environment, as those attending a predominantly racial minority school were more likely to indicate their race as "Other" (Harris, Ravert, & Sullivan, 2017). Some experimental evidence indicates that a mere contextual label of "MENA" vs. "European" was sufficient in predicting whether a racially ambiguous face was classified as White or not, despite the faces being physically identical (Chaney et al. 2021). Thus, a wide range of contextual information may be predictive of how people racially self-identify.

We also find evidence that the racial identification of some individuals of MENA ancestry may change over time and space to reflect the social context at the time they answer the survey. Campaigns encouraging identification as a group other than White during the 2010 Census seem to have had an effect in some MENA groups since in subsequent years, respondents were more likely to identify as White compared to 2010 patterns. Since then, in the years leading up to the 2020 Census, MENA community-based advocacy and campaigning has only grown (reviewed in Kayyali 2013; Matthews et al. 2017). Newly emerging data from the 2020 Census reveals that Some Other Race is now the second largest race category in the U.S. (Bahrampour

2021; Wang 2021). While the majority of these responses are from Hispanic peoples, some part of this pattern is due to a growing identification within and across many MENA communities with an identity that is not white. However, as stated previously, longitudinal patterns observed in this dataset must be interpreted cautiously, as our analyses do not account for natural shifts in population size over time.

Finally, the presence of an interviewer during data collection modulates race responses among people of MENA ancestry. When an interviewer is present, respondents were more likely to report White over other races, but they were also more likely to report Some Other Race than White. This may suggest that while the boundary between White and other races (e.g., Black, Asian) is visibly discernible, the boundaries between what is considered White and "other" (i.e., Some Other Race) are fuzzier.

Notable Differences Among U.S.-Born and Immigrant Peoples of MENA Ancestry

A third takeaway from this research is that some factors are similarly associated with racial identification for U.S.-born and immigrant people of MENA ancestry, whereas others seem to vary in a way that is consistent with select theories of immigrant acculturation. While the presence of a language other than English in the home generally signaled a weaker association with a White racial identity, the magnitude of this effect is larger for U.S.-born and longer-term immigrants than it is for more recent immigrants. It is possible that maintaining another language in the home after spending many years in the U.S., which is a predominantly English-speaking environment, is an intentional choice to keep close ties to one's heritage culture (i.e., biculturalism/integration or separation), therefore diluting the relevance of a White racial identity. However, as we do not consider which specific language is spoken at home, we cannot conclude that the language spoken at home is directly tied to one's ancestry.

Similarly, the relationship between household income and racial response varies between people of MENA ancestry born in the U.S. from those who personally immigrated to the U.S. Among U.S.-born people of MENA ancestry, larger incomes were associated with a greater likelihood of selecting a White racial response. People of MENA ancestry who are not born in the U.S. demonstrated the opposite pattern. Greater affluence among immigrants is associated with a greater likelihood to respond as Some Other Race. This result is consistent with classic sociological theories of assimilation in the American context (e.g., Gordon, 1964), suggesting that for subsequent immigrant generations, ethnicity may become more symbolic for persons of MENA ancestry and that assimilating into U.S. society, here marked by affluence, may increase the likelihood of reporting as White.

MENA immigrants are consistently more likely than U.S.-born respondents to report their race as not white; however, we notice an interesting interactive pattern between place of birth and some MENA ancestries. Specifically, people of Assyrian/Chaldean/Syriac, Egyptian, Iranian, Iraqi, Jordanian, Moroccan, and Palestinian ancestries demonstrated higher odds to report Some Other Race if they were born in the U.S. than if they immigrated. While this result may seem counterintuitive to traditional straight line American theories of assimilation (*c.f.*, Gans, 1992), it is consistent with past research specifically examining the racial experiences of second-generation MENA groups (e.g., Maghbouleh's 2017 study on Iranian-Americans, which she refers to as "generational browning"). This difference in odds between U.S.-born people of MENA ancestry and MENA immigrants is particularly notable for persons of Palestinian ancestry, with U.S.-born individuals of Palestinian ancestry demonstrating a very large odds ratio for identifying as a group other than White than those with similar ancestry not born in the U.S. Again, this finding aligns with other scholarly work examining the specific "identity crisis"

many second-generation Palestinians report experiencing in the U.S. (Mokadi & Yousef, 2022). Indeed, Mokadi and Yousef (2022) state, “Traditionally, the children of U.S.-born immigrants usually reject their parents' origins in an attempt to be fully American. However, this does not apply fully to young Palestinians,” citing complex relations with concepts of home and belonging. These results suggest that predominant theories of U.S. assimilation may not necessarily reflect the true experiences of people with MENA backgrounds in every aspect, thus highlighting the importance for more expansive research on this population.

The social context of where one lives and its relation to racial identity also varies between U.S.-born and immigrant people of MENA ancestry. Specifically, immigrants residing in the Northeast or Southern regions of the U.S. were more likely to opt for a White racial response than those residing in the West as compared to their counterparts who were born in the U.S. The proportion of MENA residents is smaller in the Northeastern and Southern regions compared to the West (Appendix Table A), and according to acculturation theories, immigrants are more likely to orient to the host culture when there are fewer others from their same cultural heritage (Berry, 1992). In our case, MENA immigrants living in the Northeast and South are surrounded by fewer MENA co-residents compared to the West, primarily due to the number of MENA residents in California (Marks et al., 2023), and this may explain why MENA immigrants in these regions are more likely to identify as White. However, Census regions are vast and there are exceptions to these geographically vast patterns (e.g., Texas and Florida have the fourth and fifth highest proportion of MENA residents in the country; Marks et al., 2023).

Therefore, where possible, it would be interesting to examine how these patterns vary through more geographically granular assessments.

Data Limitations and Considerations

We acknowledge the limitations of this study and recognize other important considerations in interpreting the results. Our analyses are based on sample data from the ACS, which samples approximately 1% of the population every year. The MENA population is small relative to some population groups and may be harder to survey. While we used weights in our initial tabulation of race responses among individuals of MENA ancestry, we did not use weights to alter the responding sample to look more like the target population for any regression analyses. Since the ACS is a household survey, in some cases, a single householder completes the survey on behalf of other household members. Therefore, it is possible that some race responses reflect the householder's perception of the race of other individuals in the household, as opposed to how those individuals may self-identify.

In addition, we identify persons of MENA descent using data collected from the ancestry question which has a high item nonresponse rate (Clark 2014). Additionally, only two ancestry responses are coded and retained (if respondents report more than two ancestries, usually the first two are taken). As a result, we may be missing individuals who are of MENA ancestry but do not respond to the question or do not report it for a number of reasons, including those who would have reported it if there was more space or those who report a MENA ancestry as their third or fourth ancestry. Therefore, our results are not fully representative of the MENA population in the U.S. and should be interpreted as such.

It is also important to note that some people may have distinct notions of ancestry and racial identity, and using ancestry data to identify persons of MENA descent may result in the

inclusion of individuals who are of MENA ancestry but have distant ties to that ancestry (see Liebler & Ortyl, 2014 for a discussion of this among American Indian and Alaska Native peoples). These individuals may be more likely to think of their race as White and less likely to self-report as MENA to the race question, which may impact the pattern of results we detect here.

We also acknowledge that given the racialized, minoritized, and politicized status of many MENA communities, some individuals of MENA descent may not wish to disclose this part of their identity to a government agency, such as the Census Bureau. Scholars have pointed out that data collected by the Census Bureau has in the past been exploited to identify neighborhoods with high populations of minority groups, such as Japanese during World War II (Seltzer and Anderson 2000) and Arabs following 9/11 (Clemetson 2004), and these concerns may continue to impact how some groups disclose information on the Census (Maghbouleh 2017). Altogether, as other scholars have remarked (Maghbouleh 2017), it is likely that the estimated MENA population in the U.S. based on data from the ACS is lower than the actual MENA population.

Broad Implications

Taken together, these findings highlight the diversity within the MENA population and indicate that those who report as White differ in meaningful dimensions from those reporting as Some Other Race or other race responses. For the most part, our findings do not show notable differences between individuals who identify as Some Other Race and those who give other race responses (e.g., Asian, Black), which suggests that White vs. not White is the primary difference in racial identification in this population, during this timeframe.

Scholars have written that historically the MENA population in the U.S. has been invisible (Awad et al. 2019; Kadi 1994; Kayyali 2013; Naber 2000). To some extent, immigrants who arrived before the 1960s may have escaped the overt racism and discrimination inflicted on other distinctly not White immigrant groups in the early 1900s by Anglicizing their names, marrying White Christians, enrolling in the U.S. military, or adopting other assimilationist practices – though, to be sure, these groups faced their own unique hardships (Aziz 2020; Naber 2000). Waves of MENA immigrants arriving after the 1960s, however, were more Muslim than Christian, and came with a strong sense of nationalism accompanied by a desire to retain an ethnically distinct identity, which made them both more visible and more racialized by White mainstream groups (Samhan 1994,1987; Naber 2000). The MENA population is phenotypically diverse. While some may pass as White in certain situations, others may choose to identify as a group other than White or are perceived and treated as such (Suleiman and Abu-Laban 1989). Naber (2000) suggests that the confusing de jure White/de facto not White status of MENA individuals within the U.S. racial hierarchy has made this group invisible and that as long as they are classified as White, they will remain invisible.

In recent years, MENA organizations, stakeholders, scholars, and individuals participating in Census Bureau studies have consistently suggested or recommended to include a dedicated MENA category in the Census and more broadly among Federal race and ethnicity data collection. While the 2020 Census did not include a separate MENA category, Census Bureau researchers have started to provide some disaggregated statistics for this population based on responses to a new White write-in box on the 2020 ACS and 2020 Census (e.g., Marks et al., 2023). Similarly, ongoing efforts by the Federal government are assessing whether the inclusion of MENA as a minimum category would help to improve the quality of Federal race

and ethnicity data, with a final decision set to be announced by the summer of 2024 (after the publication of this paper; Initial Proposals for Updating OMB's Race and Ethnicity Statistical Standards, 2023). Other institutions in the U.S. have already made such a change. In 2014, student advocates spurred the addition of a SWANA (Southwest Asian/North African) category, a decolonial alternative term to MENA, across the University of California's undergraduate application forms (Yoder 2013; SWANA Alliance n.d.). Other organizations, such as AMENA-Psy, an association of Arab and MENA psychologists, have kickstarted grassroots social media campaigns (e.g., #WeAreMENA) to encourage other researchers to include a separate MENA category on demographic forms used for research studies (AMENA-Psy 2021). Together, these efforts are centralizing the unique social experiences underlying racial identity among individuals within the MENA community.

The U.S. Census Bureau's population counts by race and ethnicity are the nation's leading statistics fueling many important programs, including language assistance for elections, loans for minority-owned businesses, and funding for government assistance for food and housing security (U.S. Census Bureau n.d.). Additionally, the OMB categories and definitions for race and ethnicity inform how other agencies and organizations collect and report data on education, crime, health, and many other topics by demographic groups. Our results indicate that a sizeable portion of people who report MENA ancestry in the U.S. do not report a single White racial identity in their unedited responses, yet their experiences would be aggregated with those who did report a White racial identity. Moreover, the extent to which people of MENA ancestry do report their race as White varies systematically by a wide set of social, economic, linguistic, ancestral, and contextual characteristics. Therefore, while it is possible to disaggregate quality statistics for other groups in the United States, the current minimum categories, which define

both MENA and European people as White, do not afford this same level of detailed information to be produced for MENA peoples.

The real-world implications of racial identification among the MENA population are hugely consequential and far-reaching, particularly as most researchers examining topics related to people of MENA origins do not have access to the unedited racial response data that were leveraged for this analysis. The absence of a distinct category for people who identify as MENA across these programs and reporting mechanisms means there is no data to track potential disparities among this population when it comes to matters such as community health and access to healthcare, which was notably apparent during the COVID-19 pandemic (Ramirez 2021). As racial identity is an ever-changing, dynamic, complex, and socially-dependent construct, we encourage steady and continued research, along with community input, to determine how best to collect data for and represent the MENA peoples across Federal statistics.

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Table 1

Unedited race responses among peoples of MENA ancestry

	Unweighted		Weighted	
Unedited Race Response	N	Percent	N	Percent
Total	*607,400*	*100*		*100*
Missing	2,900	0.5	200,800	0.4
White	446,000	73.4	33,000,000	72.0
Some Other Race	86,500	14.3	7,581,000	16.5
All Other Responses[1]	72,000	11.8	5,060,000	11.0
Detailed All Other Responses	*72,000*	*100*		
No Checkbox (write-in only)	8,900	12.4		
Single Category	26,500	36.8		
Multiple Categories	36,600	50.8		
Detailed All Other Responses (Single Category)	*26,500*	*100*		
Asian	20,800	78.6		
Black	4,900	18.6		
AIAN	370	1.4		
NHPI	340	1.3		
Detailed All Other Responses (Multiple Categories)	*36,600*	*100*		
Includes White	34,000	93.0		
Includes Asian	1,200	3.2		
Includes Black	1,100	2.9		

Notes: Unedited race responses from the ACS 2005-2019 one-year estimates for respondents who indicated a MENA ancestry. Weighted counts are based on person weights. The sum of the weighted counts (approx. 45 million) does not reflect the MENA population size since survey weights are intended to be used for a single year of data. The U.S. Census Bureau estimates 3.5 million people of MENA descent from the 2020 Census (Marks et al., 2023).

[1] The "All Other Responses" category consisted of write-in only responses/no checkboxes selected (i.e., the individual provided at least one write-in response but did not select a checkbox category); Single checkbox categories selected for Black, AIAN, Asian, or NHPI; and multiracial responses (i.e., the individual selected multiple checkbox categories). The disaggregated, detailed counts and percents for this responses type are also provided.

Table 2

Predicting Race Responses by Nativity and Time in U.S. (Odds Ratios)

Characteristics	Born in U.S.		Longer-Term Immigrants		Shorter-Term Immigrants	
	Some Other Race vs. White (OR)	All Other Responses vs. White (OR)	Some Other Race vs. White (OR)	All Other Responses vs. White (OR)	Some Other Race vs. White (OR)	All Other Responses vs. White (OR)
(Intercept)	**0.1**	**0.09**	**0.33**	**0.09**	**0.36**	**0.09**
Demographic Characteristics						
Age						
Less than 18 years	**0.96**	**1.69**	0.71	1.24	**0.88**	**1.12**
18 to 24 years	**0.92**	**1.32**	1.05	**1.24**	**1.18**	**1.25**
25 to 44 years (Ref)						
45 to 64 years	**0.73**	**0.84**	**0.63**	0.96	**0.78**	0.98
65 years and older	**0.13**	**0.47**	**0.37**	**0.67**	**0.69**	**0.85**
Sex						
Male (Ref)						
Female	**0.96**	**0.95**	**0.93**	**0.94**	**0.89**	0.98
Language Knowledge						
English only (Ref)						
English + other, High English proficiency	**1.81**	**1.21**	**1.45**	**1.68**	**1.08**	**1.37**
English + other, Low English proficiency	**1.38**	**1.32**	**1.99**	**1.96**	**1.19**	**1.59**
Not answered	**1.64**	**1.07**	*N/A*[1]	*N/A*[1]	**1.21**	**1.66**

Table 2 (continued)

Characteristics	Born in U.S.		Longer-Term Immigrants		Shorter-Term Immigrants	
	Some Other Race vs. White (OR)	All Other Responses vs. White (OR)	Some Other Race vs. White (OR)	All Other Responses vs. White (OR)	Some Other Race vs. White (OR)	All Other Responses vs. White (OR)
Education of Householder						
Less than high school (Ref)						
High school, GED, or some college	**0.85**	**0.64**	**0.81**	**0.77**	**0.9**	**0.91**
Bachelor's degree or higher	**0.86**	**0.62**	**0.65**	**0.64**	**0.65**	**0.66**
Median Household Income						
Less than $25,000 (Ref)						
$25,000 to $49,999	**0.71**	**0.88**	1.01	1.03	**0.94**	0.95
$50,000 to $74,999	**0.72**	**0.92**	**1.11**	1.01	1.03	**0.92**
$75,000 to $99,999	**0.67**	1.04	**1.09**	0.94	1.02	**0.79**
$100,000 to $124,999	**0.69**	0.94	**1.1**	**0.9**	1.04	**0.84**
$125,000 or more	**0.68**	**0.91**	1.05	**0.85**	**1.09**	**0.83**
Housing Tenure						
Owner (Ref)						
Renter	**1.14**	**1.27**	**1.17**	**1.08**	**1.15**	**1.06**

Table 2 (continued)

Characteristics	Born in U.S.		Longer-Term Immigrants		Shorter-Term Immigrants	
	Some Other Race vs. White (OR)	All Other Responses vs. White (OR)	Some Other Race vs. White (OR)	All Other Responses vs. White (OR)	Some Other Race vs. White (OR)	All Other Responses vs. White (OR)
Ancestry						
MENA Ancestry						
MENA only (Ref)						
Mixed MENA and non-MENA	**0.40**	**0.56**	**0.48**	**0.33**	**0.49**	**0.31**
Detailed Ancestry						
Lebanese (Ref)						
Armenian	**1.31**	1.02	0.94	**1.71**	**0.64**	**1.36**
Assyrian/Chaldean/ Syriac	**3.38**	**2.79**	**2.25**	**3.05**	**1.15**	**2.38**
Iranian	**2.28**	**1.94**	**1.47**	**3.3**	**1.23**	**3.45**
Israeli	**0.78**	1.06	**0.31**	**0.44**	**0.31**	**0.45**
Turkish	**1.44**	**1.46**	**0.71**	1.03	**0.71**	1.07
Syrian	**1.18**	**1.13**	0.98	**1.32**	1.08	**1.49**
Egyptian	**4.01**	**2.87**	**3.18**	**2.7**	**2.22**	**2.35**
Palestinian	**5.29**	**3.51**	**2.25**	**2.02**	**1.82**	**1.96**
Jordanian	**2.68**	**1.42**	**1.51**	**2.1**	**1.43**	**2.15**
Moroccan	**3.53**	**1.6**	**1.36**	**1.64**	**1.57**	**1.57**
Iraqi	**3.47**	**1.88**	**1.29**	**1.85**	**1.15**	**1.99**
Arab/Arabic	**4.95**	**2.08**	**2.83**	**2.8**	**3.35**	**3.70**
Other MENA	**3.32**	**2.04**	**2.25**	**2.57**	**2.81**	**3.36**

Table 2 (continued)

	Born in U.S.		Longer-Term Immigrants		Shorter-Term Immigrants	
Characteristics	Some Other Race vs. White (OR)	All Other Responses vs. White (OR)	Some Other Race vs. White (OR)	All Other Responses vs. White (OR)	Some Other Race vs. White (OR)	All Other Responses vs. White (OR)
Contextual Influences						
Racial Minority in Household (%)	**1.01**	**1.04**	**1.01**	**1.04**	**1.02**	**1.05**
MENA in County (%)	**7464000**	**0.01**	1.10	1.29	**0.04**	**0.04**
Region						
West (Ref)						
Northeast	**0.61**	**0.71**	**0.57**	**0.8**	**0.73**	**0.92**
Midwest	**0.66**	**0.77**	**0.82**	1.02	**0.87**	0.95
South	**0.69**	**0.7**	**0.67**	**0.76**	**0.75**	**0.80**
Logistical Factors						
Survey Year						
2005	1.07	**0.82**	**0.77**	0.96	**1.09**	**1.27**
2006	1.00	**1.24**	**0.71**	**0.86**	0.94	**1.24**
2007	**0.89**	0.92	**0.70**	1.01	**0.83**	**1.22**
2008	1.03	**1.13**	**0.73**	1.05	**0.84**	**1.25**
2009	**1.21**	1.05	**0.71**	**1.22**	**0.82**	**1.40**
2010 (Ref)						
2011	0.96	1.01	**0.79**	0.98	**0.77**	**0.87**
2012	0.95	**0.85**	**0.75**	**0.90**	**0.66**	**0.77**
2013	**0.90**	**0.85**	**0.75**	**0.74**	**0.69**	**0.70**
2014	1.01	**0.81**	**0.73**	**0.78**	**0.62**	**0.66**
2015	1.06	1.07	**0.75**	**0.76**	**0.63**	**0.63**
2016	**1.46**	0.97	**0.76**	**0.76**	**0.64**	**0.67**

Table 2 (continued)

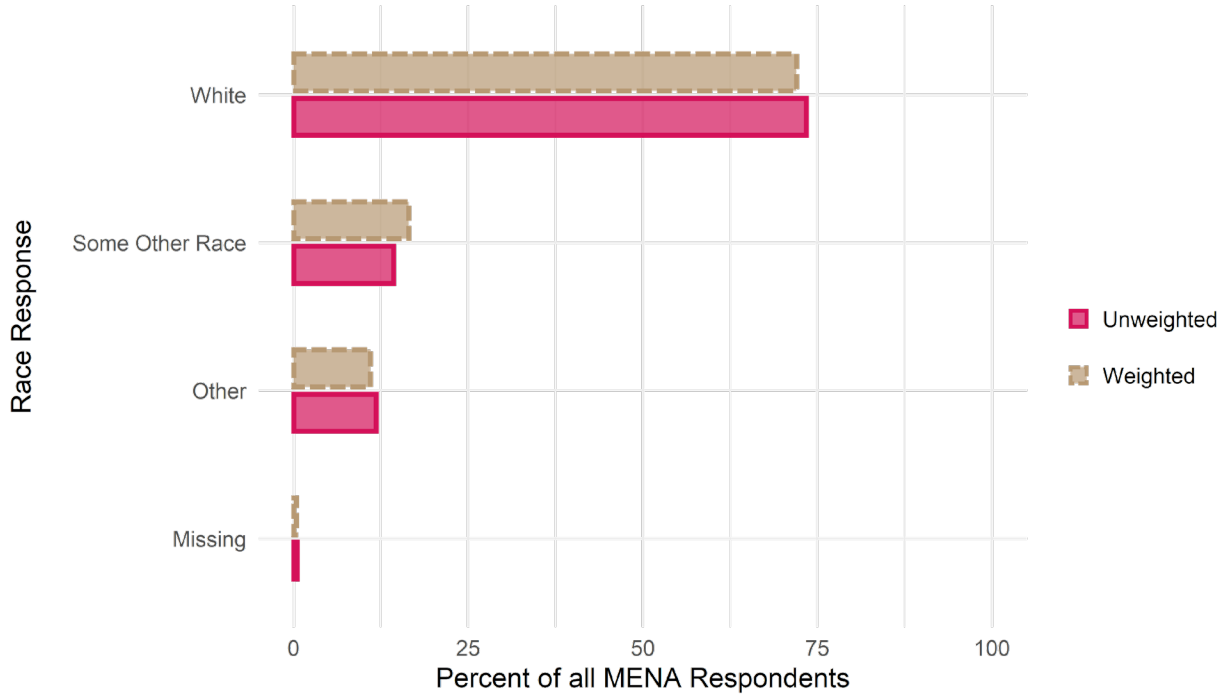
	Born in U.S.		Longer-Term Immigrants		Shorter-Term Immigrants	
Characteristics	Some Other Race vs. White (OR)	All Other Responses vs. White (OR)	Some Other Race vs. White (OR)	All Other Responses vs. White (OR)	Some Other Race vs. White (OR)	All Other Responses vs. White (OR)
2017	**1.15**	**0.87**	**0.72**	**0.73**	**0.67**	**0.68**
2018	**1.29**	**1.16**	**0.79**	**0.75**	**0.64**	**0.58**
2019	**1.17**	0.94	**0.76**	**0.75**	**0.6**	**0.52**
Response Mode						
Mail or Internet (Ref)						
Other	**1.26**	**0.55**	**1.27**	**0.28**	**1.54**	**0.32**

Notes. Odds ratios indicating predicted unedited race responses from the ACS 2005-2019 one-year estimates for respondents who indicated a MENA ancestry (N=607,400). Reference levels among categorical predictors are indicated by (Ref), and statistically significant predictors (i.e., $p < 0.05$) are indicated in boldface. Separate models were computed for respondents born in the US, those who immigrated to the US and have resided in US for longer than 17 years (median), and those who immigrated to the US and have resided in US for less than 17 years (median). SOR = Some Other Race; OR = Odds Ratio

[1]Since only those under the age of five did not answer the language knowledge question, the model coefficient is not available among immigrant respondents who have resided in US for longer than 17 years.

Figure 1

Unedited race responses among peoples of MENA ancestry



Note. Unedited race responses from the ACS 2005-2019 one-year estimates for respondents who indicated a MENA ancestry (N=607,400). Weighted counts use person weights. The "Other" racial response category consisted of respondents who provided a write-in response but did not select a checkbox category; selected a single non-white, non-SOR checkbox (Black, AIAN, Asian, or NHPI); or selected multiple checkbox categories (multiracial).

Figure 2

Odds ratios of characteristics that predict unedited race response

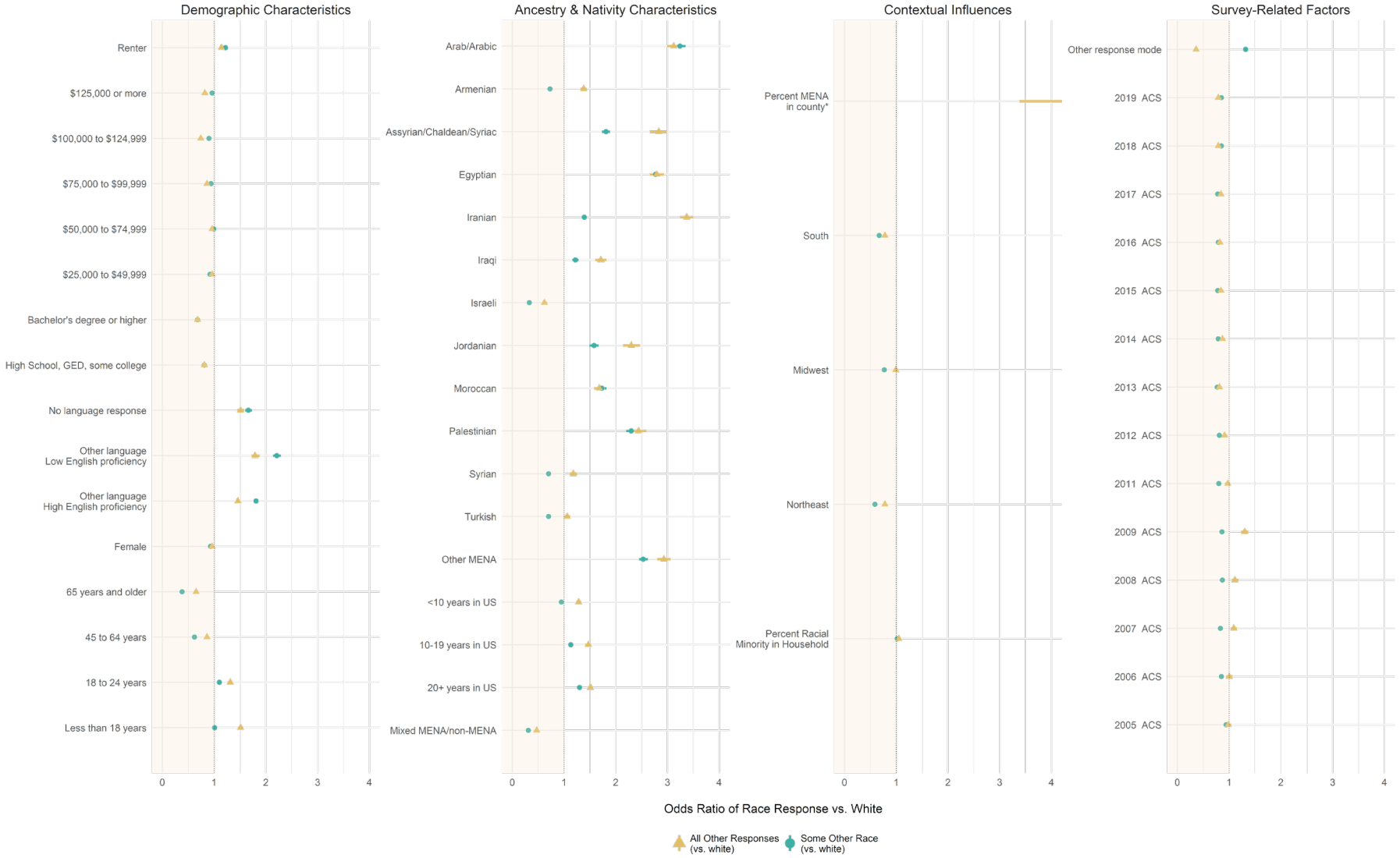


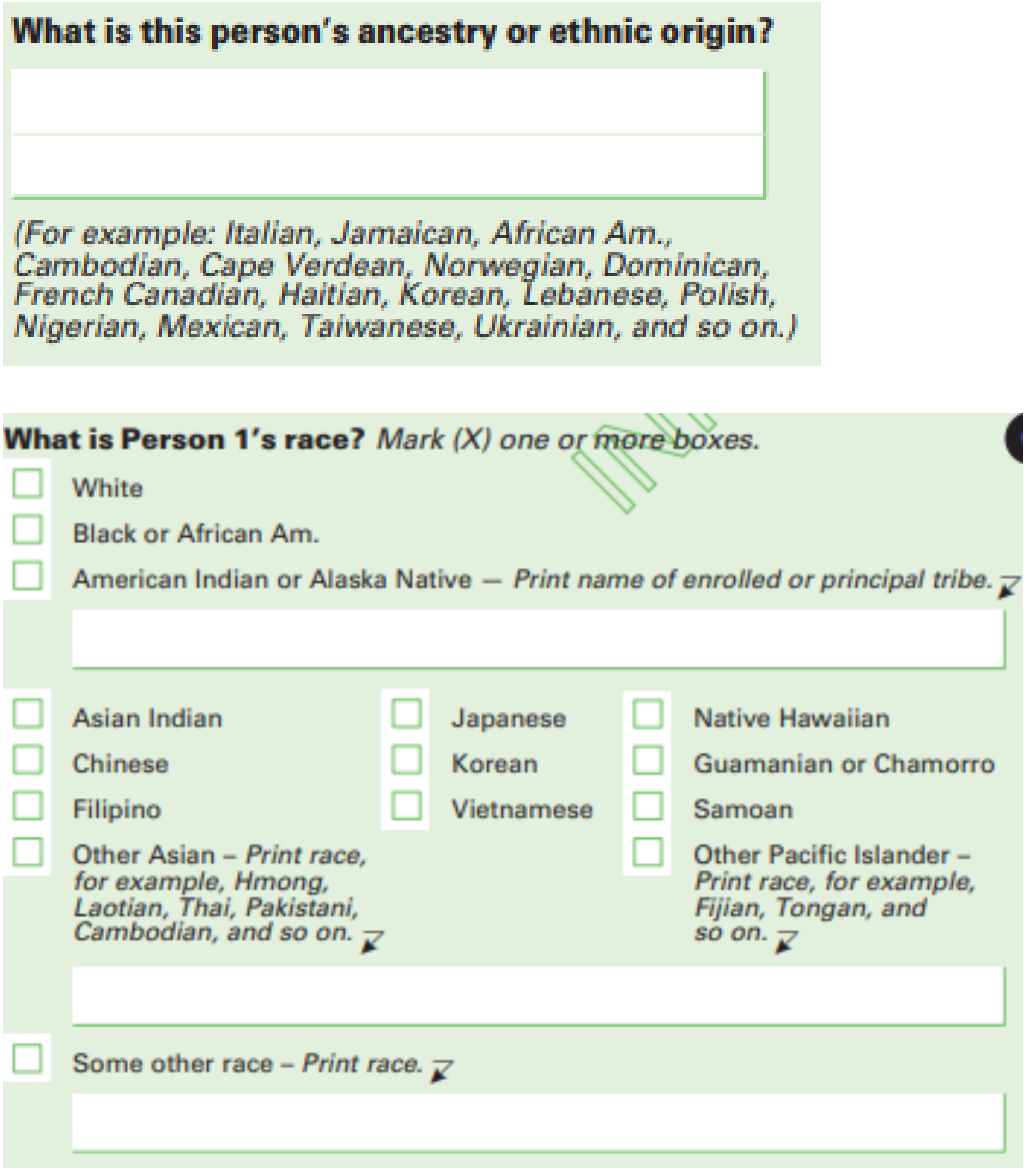
Figure 2 (continued)

Note. Odds ratios of demographic, contextual, ancestral, and ACS survey characteristics predicting unedited race responses from the ACS 2005-2019 one-year estimates for respondents who indicated a MENA ancestry. Odds ratios less than one (shaded region) indicate a greater probability of selecting White over Some Other Race (SOR) or other options. Odds ratios greater than one indicate a greater likelihood of selecting Some Other Race (blue) or other race responses (yellow) over White. Error lines indicate 95% confidence intervals.

* The odds ratio for percent MENA in county for predicting both SOR and other race responses exceeded the bounds of the graph.

Appendix Figure A

Ancestry Question and Race Question from 2019 ACS



Note: Screenshots of the ancestry question (top) and race question (bottom) from the 2019 American Community Survey. Images taken from public U.S. Census Bureau information documentation (retrieved from https://www2.census.gov/programs-surveys/acs/methodology/questionnaires/2019/)

Appendix Table A

Composition of the Analytic Sample, N = 604,500

Characteristics	Total (%)	White Race Respondents (N = 446,000) (%)	Some Other Race Respondents (N = 86,500) (%)	All Other Race Respondents (N = 72,000) (%)
Demographic Characteristics				
Age				
Less than 18 years	25.4	24.9	26.1	28.0
18 to 24 years	9.0	8.4	11.2	10.2
25 to 44 years	28.8	27.6	34.6	29.0
45 to 64 years	25.2	26.3	21.3	23.7
65 years and older	11.5	12.9	6.7	9.1
Sex				
Male	51.7	51.0	53.9	53.3
Female	48.3	49.0	46.1	46.7
Language Knowledge				
English only	39.3	45.3	19.4	26.2
Other language, High English proficiency	46.4	41.7	62.3	56.1
Other language, Low English proficiency	7.3	6.3	10.7	9.3
Not answered	7.0	6.7	7.6	8.3
Education of Householder				
Less than high school	7.9	6.7	12.3	10.4
High school, GED, or some college	38.7	38.1	41.5	39.2
Bachelor's degree or higher	53.4	55.3	46.2	50.4

Appendix Table A (continued)

Characteristics	Total (%)	White Race Respondents (%)	Some Other Race Respondents (%)	All Other Race Respondents (%)
Median Household Income				
Less than $25,000	17.4	15.6	23.4	21.2
$25,000 to $49,999	17.9	17.1	20.1	20.1
$50,000 to $74,999	15.2	15.1	15.5	15.3
$75,000 to $99,999	12.0	12.5	10.7	10.7
$100,000 to $124,999	9.7	10.2	8.4	8.5
$125,000 or more	27.9	29.6	22	24.3
Tenure				
Owner	66.5	69.7	55.7	60.0
Renter	33.5	30.3	44.3	40.0
Ancestry & Time in U.S.				
MENA Ancestry				
MENA only	71.9	67.8	89.8	75.9
Mixed MENA and non-MENA	28.1	32.2	10.2	24.1
Detailed Ancestry				
Arab/Arabic	8.4	6.1	17	12.3
Armenian	15.2	17.4	9.6	8.8
Assyrian/Chaldean/Syriac	3.1	2.7	4.6	3.5
Egyptian	6.8	5.8	11.3	7.4
Iranian	14.2	12.5	14.1	24.8
Iraqi	3.0	2.8	3.6	3.4
Israeli	4.3	5.2	1.5	2.0
Jordanian	1.9	1.7	2.5	2.1
Lebanese	17.8	21.1	7.6	9.2
Moroccan	2.5	2.1	3.4	3.5

Appendix Table A (continued)

Characteristics	Total (%)	White Race Respondents (%)	Some Other Race Respondents (%)	All Other Race Respondents (%)
Palestinian	3.1	2.6	5.2	3.8
Syrian	5.6	6.6	2.4	3.0
Turkish	6.3	7.2	3.5	4.5
Other MENA	7.9	6.2	13.7	11.7
Years in US				
U.S. Born	52.5	56.9	38.4	42.4
20+ years in US	21.3	20.2	24.3	24.9
10-19 years in US	11.1	9.9	15.5	13.3
<10 years in US	15.0	13.0	21.9	19.4
Contextual Influences				
Region				
West	31.7	29.7	37.8	36.3
Northeast	24.4	26.4	18.5	18.9
Midwest	21.0	20.7	23.3	20.5
South	22.9	23.2	20.4	24.3
Logistical Factors				
Survey Year				
2005	5.5	5.6	5.9	4.5
2006	5.7	5.9	5.7	4.7
2007	5.7	5.9	5.6	5.0
2008	5.7	5.8	5.5	5.4
2009	6.0	6.1	5.7	5.9
2010	6.1	5.8	7.1	6.8
2011	6.8	6.7	6.8	7.4
2012	7.6	7.6	7.5	7.9
2013	7.0	7.0	7.1	6.8

Appendix Table A (continued)

Characteristics	Total (%)	White Race Respondents (%)	Some Other Race Respondents (%)	All Other Race Respondents (%)
2014	7.5	7.6	7.3	7.4
2015	7.6	7.6	7.6	7.7
2016	7.5	7.4	7.4	7.7
2017	7.1	7.1	7.1	7.6
2018	7.2	7.1	7.1	7.8
2019	6.9	6.9	6.7	7.4
Response Mode				
Mail or Internet	69.9	71.0	55.9	80.1
Other	30.1	29.0	44.1	19.9

Notes: Sample composition from the ACS 2005-2019 one-year estimates for respondents who indicated a MENA ancestry (unweighted). SOR = Some Other Race.

Appendix Table B

Odds Ratios Predicting Overall Race Responses

Characteristics	Some Other Race Response			All Other Responses		
	Odds ratio	SE	95% CI	Odds ratio	SE	95% CI
(Intercept)	**0.19**	**0.03**	**(0.18, 0.2)**	**0.05**	**0.04**	**(0.05, 0.06)**
Demographic Characteristics						
Age						
Less than 18 years	1.01	0.01	(0.98, 1.03)	**1.51**	**0.02**	**(1.46, 1.56)**
18 to 24 years	**1.10**	**0.01**	**(1.07, 1.13)**	**1.31**	**0.02**	**(1.26, 1.35)**
25 to 44 years (Ref)						
45 to 64 years	**0.62**	**0.01**	**(0.61, 0.64)**	**0.86**	**0.01**	**(0.83, 0.88)**
65 years and older	**0.38**	**0.02**	**(0.37, 0.39)**	**0.65**	**0.02**	**(0.62, 0.67)**
Sex						
Male (Ref)						
Female	**0.93**	**0.01**	**(0.92, 0.95)**	**0.96**	**0.01**	**(0.95, 0.98)**
Language Knowledge						
English only (Ref)						
English + Other, High English proficiency	**1.81**	**0.01**	**(1.77, 1.85)**	**1.46**	**0.01**	**(1.42, 1.5)**
English + Other, Low English proficiency	**2.21**	**0.02**	**(2.14, 2.29)**	**1.79**	**0.02**	**(1.72, 1.88)**
Not answered	**1.66**	**0.02**	**(1.6, 1.73)**	**1.51**	**0.02**	**(1.45, 1.58)**
Education of Householder						
Less than high school (Ref)						
High school, GED, or some college	**0.81**	**0.01**	**(0.78, 0.83)**	**0.81**	**0.02**	**(0.78, 0.84)**
Bachelor's degree or higher	**0.68**	**0.01**	**(0.66, 0.7)**	**0.68**	**0.02**	**(0.66, 0.71)**

Appendix Table B (continued)

Characteristics	Some Other Race Response			All Other Responses		
	Odds ratio	SE	95% CI	Odds ratio	SE	95% CI
Median Household Income						
Less than $25,000 (Ref)						
$25,000 to $49,999	**0.92**	**0.01**	**(0.9, 0.94)**	**0.96**	**0.02**	**(0.93, 0.99)**
$50,000 to $74,999	0.99	0.01	(0.97, 1.02)	**0.96**	**0.02**	**(0.92, 0.99)**
$75,000 to $99,999	**0.94**	**0.02**	**(0.91, 0.97)**	**0.86**	**0.02**	**(0.83, 0.89)**
$100,000 to $124,999	**0.90**	**0.02**	**(0.87, 0.93)**	**0.74**	**0.02**	**(0.71, 0.77)**
$125,000 or more	**0.96**	**0.01**	**(0.94, 0.99)**	**0.82**	**0.02**	**(0.79, 0.85)**
Tenure						
Owner (Ref)						
Renter	**1.22**	**0.01**	**(1.2, 1.24)**	**1.14**	**0.01**	**(1.11, 1.17)**
Ancestry & Time in U.S.						
MENA Ancestry						
MENA only (Ref)						
Mixed MENA and non-MENA	**0.31**	**0.01**	**(0.3, 0.32)**	**0.47**	**0.01**	**(0.45, 0.48)**
Detailed Ancestry						
Lebanese (Ref)						
Arab/Arabic	**3.24**	**0.02**	**(3.14, 3.35)**	**3.12**	**0.02**	**(2.99, 3.26)**
Armenian	**0.73**	**0.02**	**(0.70, 0.75)**	**1.38**	**0.02**	**(1.32, 1.44)**
Assyrian/Chaldean/Syriac	**1.81**	**0.02**	**(1.73, 1.89)**	**2.83**	**0.03**	**(2.66, 2.99)**
Egyptian	**2.77**	**0.02**	**(2.68, 2.87)**	**2.79**	**0.02**	**(2.66, 2.93)**
Iranian	**1.39**	**0.02**	**(1.34, 1.43)**	**3.37**	**0.02**	**(3.24, 3.50)**
Iraqi	**1.22**	**0.02**	**(1.16, 1.28)**	**1.71**	**0.03**	**(1.60, 1.82)**
Israeli	**0.33**	**0.03**	**(0.31, 0.35)**	**0.62**	**0.04**	**(0.58, 0.67)**
Jordanian	**1.58**	**0.03**	**(1.49, 1.67)**	**2.30**	**0.04**	**(2.14, 2.47)**
Moroccan	**1.73**	**0.03**	**(1.64, 1.82)**	**1.68**	**0.03**	**(1.58, 1.79)**
Palestinian	**2.30**	**0.02**	**(2.20, 2.40)**	**2.44**	**0.03**	**(2.30, 2.59)**
Syrian	**0.70**	**0.03**	**(0.67, 0.74)**	**1.18**	**0.03**	**(1.11, 1.25)**

Appendix Table B (continued)

Characteristics	Some Other Race Response			All Other Responses		
	Odds ratio	SE	95% CI	Odds ratio	SE	95% CI
Turkish	**0.70**	**0.02**	**(0.67, 0.73)**	**1.06**	**0.03**	**(1.00, 1.12)**
Other MENA	**2.53**	**0.02**	**(2.45, 2.62)**	**2.93**	**0.02**	**(2.80, 3.06)**
Years in U.S.						
U.S.-born (Ref)						
20+ years in U.S.	**1.30**	**0.01**	**(1.26, 1.33)**	**1.51**	**0.02**	**(1.46, 1.56)**
10-19 years in U.S.	**1.13**	**0.01**	**(1.10, 1.17)**	**1.47**	**0.02**	**(1.41, 1.52)**
<10 years in U.S.	**0.95**	**0.01**	**(0.93, 0.98)**	**1.28**	**0.02**	**(1.24, 1.33)**
Contextual Influences						
Percent Racial Minority in Household	**1.02**	**0**	**(1.02, 1.02)**	**1.05**	**0**	**(1.05, 1.05)**
Percent of MENA in County	**189.5**	**0.34**	**(97.71, 367.7)**	**7.90**	**0.43**	**(3.38, 18.48)**
Region						
West (Ref)						
Northeast	**0.59**	**0.01**	**(0.58, 0.60)**	**0.78**	**0.01**	**(0.76, 0.81)**
Midwest	**0.77**	**0.01**	**(0.75, 0.79)**	0.99	0.01	(0.96, 1.02)
South	**0.67**	**0.01**	**(0.66, 0.69)**	**0.78**	**0.01**	**(0.76, 0.80)**
Logistical Factors						
Survey Year						
2005	**0.94**	**0.02**	**(0.90, 0.99)**	0.98	0.03	(0.92, 1.04)
2006	**0.85**	**0.02**	**(0.82, 0.89)**	1.00	0.03	(0.94, 1.06)
2007	**0.83**	**0.02**	**(0.79, 0.87)**	**1.09**	**0.03**	**(1.03, 1.15)**
2008	**0.87**	**0.02**	**(0.83, 0.91)**	**1.11**	**0.03**	**(1.05, 1.18)**
2009	**0.86**	**0.02**	**(0.82, 0.9)**	**1.30**	**0.03**	**(1.23, 1.37)**
2010 (Ref)						
2011	**0.80**	**0.02**	**(0.77, 0.83)**	0.97	0.03	(0.92, 1.02)
2012	**0.81**	**0.02**	**(0.77, 0.84)**	**0.91**	**0.03**	**(0.87, 0.96)**
2013	**0.77**	**0.02**	**(0.74, 0.80)**	**0.81**	**0.03**	**(0.77, 0.86)**
2014	**0.79**	**0.02**	**(0.76, 0.82)**	**0.87**	**0.03**	**(0.83, 0.92)**

Appendix Table B (continued)

Characteristics	Some Other Race Response			All Other Responses		
	Odds ratio	SE	95% CI	Odds ratio	SE	95% CI
2015	**0.78**	**0.02**	**(0.75, 0.81)**	**0.84**	**0.03**	**(0.80, 0.89)**
2016	**0.79**	**0.02**	**(0.76, 0.82)**	**0.82**	**0.03**	**(0.78, 0.86)**
2017	**0.78**	**0.02**	**(0.75, 0.82)**	**0.84**	**0.03**	**(0.79, 0.88)**
2018	**0.85**	**0.02**	**(0.81, 0.89)**	**0.79**	**0.03**	**(0.75, 0.84)**
2019	**0.85**	**0.02**	**(0.81, 0.88)**	**0.79**	**0.03**	**(0.75, 0.83)**
Response Mode						
Mail or Internet (Ref)						
Other	**1.32**	**0.01**	**(1.29, 1.34)**	**0.36**	**0.01**	**(0.35, 0.37)**

Notes: Odds ratios indicating predicted unedited race responses from the ACS 2005-2019 one-year estimates for respondents who indicated a MENA ancestry (unweighted). Reference levels among categorical predictors are indicated by (Ref), and statistically significant predictors (i.e., $p < 0.05$) are indicated in boldface.

Appendix Table C

Composition of the Analytic Sample by Nativity and Time in U.S.

	Born in U.S.				Longer-Term Immigrants				Shorter-Term Immigrants			
Characteristics	Total (%)	White (%)	SOR (%)	All Other (%)	Total (%)	White (%)	SOR (%)	All Other (%)	Total (%)	White (%)	SOR (%)	All Other (%)
Demographic Characteristics												
Age												
< 18	41.4	38.1	54.1	54.9	0	0	0	0	15.3	15.2	15.5	15.4
18 to 24	11.2	10.5	14.2	13.8	1.9	1.7	2.8	1.9	11.1	9.7	14.6	12.6
25 to 44	22.7	22.7	23.7	21.3	22.5	20.8	30.9	21.1	48.3	48.1	49.8	46.7
45 to 64	16.6	19.1	6.4	7.3	51.3	50.9	49.7	55	18.8	19.9	15.3	18.6
> 65	8.2	9.7	1.5	2.7	24.3	26.6	16.5	21.9	6.5	7.1	4.8	6.6
Sex												
Male	49.7	49.4	50.6	50.5	56.3	55.6	57.2	58.5	51.6	50.4	54.9	52.4
Female	50.3	50.6	49.4	49.5	43.7	44.4	42.8	41.5	48.4	49.6	45.1	47.6
Language Knowledge												
English only	64	69.5	35.2	49.4	16.8	18.7	12.7	12.2	7.4	7.7	7	6.5
English + other (High English)	22.8	18.8	45.4	31.3	73.7	72.2	76.2	78.1	71.3	71.8	70.1	71
English + other (Low English)	0.8	0.7	1.4	1.3	9.5	9.1	11.1	9.7	19.3	18.6	20.8	20.3
Not answered	12.4	11	17.9	18					2	1.9	2.1	2.3

Appendix Table C (continued)

Characteristics	Born in U.S. Total (%)	Born in U.S. White (%)	Born in U.S. SOR (%)	Born in U.S. All Other (%)	Longer-Term Immigrants Total (%)	Longer-Term Immigrants White (%)	Longer-Term Immigrants SOR (%)	Longer-Term Immigrants All Other (%)	Shorter-Term Immigrants Total (%)	Shorter-Term Immigrants White (%)	Shorter-Term Immigrants SOR (%)	Shorter-Term Immigrants All Other (%)
Education of Householder												
Less than high school	5.5	4.5	10.5	7.9	10.5	9.6	13	11.8	10.8	9.5	13.6	12.6
High school, GED, or some college	41	40.6	42.2	42.5	35.6	34.9	38.9	35	36.7	34.4	42.8	38.4
Bachelor's degree or higher	53.6	54.9	47.2	49.6	54	55.5	48	53.2	52.5	56.1	43.6	49
Median Household Income												
< $25,000	13.1	11.7	19.9	17.9	16	15.7	16.9	16	28	26	32.3	30.4
$25,000 - $49,999	16.2	15.5	19.3	18.7	16	15.6	16.5	17	23.3	22.7	23.7	24.8
$50,000 - $74,999	15.4	15.3	15.8	15.6	14.6	14.2	15.6	15.1	15.2	15.2	15.2	15.3
$75,000 - $99,999	13.1	13.5	11.1	11.5	11.6	11.6	11.9	11.3	10.1	10.6	9.4	8.9
$100,000 - $124,999	10.8	11.2	9	9.1	9.9	9.9	10	9.6	7.1	7.5	6.3	6.6
> $125,000	31.4	32.7	24.9	27.3	32	32.9	29	30.9	16.4	18	13.2	14
Tenure												
Owner	73.8	76.5	62.4	63.8	75.5	76.8	70.3	75.5	42	43.9	36.6	41
Renter	26.2	23.5	37.6	36.2	24.5	23.2	29.7	24.5	58	56.1	63.4	59

Appendix Table C (continued)

Characteristics	Born in U.S. Total (%)	Born in U.S. White (%)	Born in U.S. SOR (%)	Born in U.S. All Other (%)	Longer-Term Immigrants Total (%)	Longer-Term Immigrants White (%)	Longer-Term Immigrants SOR (%)	Longer-Term Immigrants All Other (%)	Shorter-Term Immigrants Total (%)	Shorter-Term Immigrants White (%)	Shorter-Term Immigrants SOR (%)	Shorter-Term Immigrants All Other (%)
Ancestry												
MENA Ancestry												
MENA only	51.8	48.2	79.1	51.7	93.5	92.9	96	93.3	94.8	94.4	96.8	93.9
Mixed	48.2	51.8	20.9	48.3	6.5	7.1	4	6.7	5.2	5.6	3.2	6.1
Detailed Ancestry												
Arab/Arabic	7.5	5.5	18.5	12.4	7.4	5.9	12.1	9.1	11.3	7.9	19.4	14.9
Armenian	17.4	19.3	9.8	10.2	15.9	17.5	13.6	11	9.9	12.2	6.2	5
Assyrian, Chaldean, Syriac	2.7	2.4	5.1	3.5	4	3.4	6	4.6	3	3.1	2.8	2.6
Egyptian	4.7	3.8	9.5	7.3	7.9	7.1	12	7.1	10	9.7	12.7	7.7
Iranian	9.3	8	11.2	17.5	24.7	22.9	22.1	37.3	14.8	13.9	11.1	23.8
Iraqi	1.4	1.3	2.3	1.7	2.3	2.4	2.3	2	7	7.3	6.2	6.8
Israeli	4	4.4	2	3.2	4.8	6.4	1.2	1.1	4.4	6.1	1.2	1.2
Jordanian	1.4	1.2	2.4	1.9	2.2	2.1	2.4	2.1	2.6	2.6	2.6	2.5
Lebanese	26.4	30	10.5	14	10.3	11.6	7.5	7	6.1	7	4.6	4.4
Moroccan	2	1.5	3.6	4.4	1.9	2	1.7	1.6	4	4	4.5	3.8
Palestinian	3.4	2.6	7.6	5.2	3.5	3.2	5	3.3	2.1	2	2.6	2.2
Syrian	7.8	9	2.5	3.7	3	3.4	2.1	2.2	3.2	3.5	2.6	2.6
Turkish	5.3	5.8	2.6	4.2	5.4	6.4	2.7	3.5	9.5	11.6	5.3	5.8
Other MENA	6.5	5.2	12.5	10.7	6.7	5.8	9.4	8.1	12.2	9.2	18.4	16.5

Appendix Table C (continued)

Characteristics	Born in U.S. Total (%)	Born in U.S. White (%)	Born in U.S. SOR (%)	Born in U.S. All Other (%)	Longer-Term Immigrants Total (%)	Longer-Term Immigrants White (%)	Longer-Term Immigrants SOR (%)	Longer-Term Immigrants All Other (%)	Shorter-Term Immigrants Total (%)	Shorter-Term Immigrants White (%)	Shorter-Term Immigrants SOR (%)	Shorter-Term Immigrants All Other (%)
Contextual Influences												
Region												
West	26.5	24.4	35.7	34.1	41.5	39.9	46.4	43.6	33.5	33.7	33.4	32.7
Northeast	27	29.2	18.3	18.7	21.2	23	16.4	17.7	21.6	22.4	20.3	20.3
Midwest	23.5	23.1	26.6	23.2	16.1	15.4	19	16.3	20.4	19.5	23	20.7
South	23	23.3	19.4	24	21.2	21.7	18.2	22.4	24.5	24.5	23.3	26.4
Logistical Factors												
Survey Year												
2005	5.8	6	5.7	4.4	4.8	4.9	5.1	4.3	5.5	5.2	6.8	4.9
2006	5.9	6.2	5.3	4.6	5.2	5.4	5.3	4.2	5.8	5.6	6.6	5.2
2007	6	6.1	5.5	5.1	5.4	5.5	5.3	4.8	5.5	5.5	5.8	5
2008	6	6.1	5.6	5.3	5.5	5.6	5.4	5.5	5.4	5.3	5.6	5.4
2009	6.1	6.3	5.5	5.8	5.9	6	5.6	6.2	5.8	5.7	6.1	5.9
2010	6.1	6	6.6	6.2	6.1	5.6	7.5	7.2	6.2	5.6	7.3	7.3
2011	6.8	6.8	6.7	6.5	6.6	6.3	6.8	7.6	6.9	6.5	7	8.5
2012	7.6	7.6	7.6	7.3	7.7	7.6	7.7	8.3	7.7	7.7	7.2	8.5
2013	6.9	6.9	6.9	6.5	7.1	7.2	7.2	6.8	7.1	7.2	7	7.1
2014	7.4	7.4	7.4	7.4	7.7	7.8	7.6	7.5	7.7	7.9	7	7.4
2015	7.4	7.2	7.7	8.2	7.8	7.9	7.7	7.5	7.8	8.1	7.3	7.3
2016	7.3	7.2	7.7	7.9	7.6	7.7	7.3	7.2	7.7	7.9	7.1	7.8
2017	6.9	6.7	7.2	8	7.3	7.5	6.9	7.2	7.4	7.6	7	7.2
2018	7	6.8	7.3	8.6	7.7	7.6	7.6	7.9	7	7.3	6.5	6.4
2019	6.9	6.6	7.3	8.1	7.5	7.6	7	7.8	6.5	7	5.7	5.9

Appendix Table C (continued)

	Born in U.S.				Longer-Term Immigrants				Shorter-Term Immigrants			
Characteristics	Total (%)	White (%)	SOR (%)	All Other (%)	Total (%)	White (%)	SOR (%)	All Other (%)	Total (%)	White (%)	SOR (%)	All Other (%)
Response Mode												
Mail or Internet	73	74.3	59.5	77.2	70.3	69.4	60.4	86.7	62.8	63.7	48.5	78.4
Other	27	25.7	40.5	22.8	29.7	30.6	39.6	13.3	37.2	36.3	51.5	21.6

Note: Sample composition from the ACS 2005-2019 one-year estimates for respondents who indicated a MENA ancestry (unweighted). Longer-term immigrants are defined as greater than the median number of years in the U.S. across all immigrants (17 years) whereas shorter-term immigrants are defined as less than the median number of years. SOR = Some Other Race.